

PART ONE: WHO LIVES IN AFFORDABLE FAMILY HOUSING?

CHAPTER ONE: FAMILIES IN NEED

Affordable family housing is developed for families with some form of government assistance to insure that housing costs do not consume too much of that family's income. Who are these families and why do they need affordable housing? They are often our neighbors, the people we see on the bus, our children's playmates, and the workers in our communities.

Families in need

They are people who have been paying a high percentage of their income on rent, often living in overcrowded or substandard conditions. Their problem is easy to identify; their jobs do not pay them sufficient income for them to participate in inflated local housing markets, either as renters or homeowners, without paying more than 30 per cent of their incomes for housing. As much as any of us, they need and deserve to live in healthy, affordable places where they can raise their children and have enough every month to pay their other bills. Despite a severe shortage in many areas, all over the country families are living in well-designed, government-subsidized housing. In this chapter you will meet some of these people, and read about why they and many others need well-designed affordable housing.

What is "affordable housing"?

According to the federal government, housing is considered affordable if it consumes no more than 30 per cent of a household's income. For very low-income families 30 per cent may be too much to allow enough for the rest of the family expenses (see the Foreword for more detail). Many families in America pay far more than 30 per cent on housing every month, and this situation has been getting worse. "From 1978 to 1993, the percentage of very-low-income households (see sidebar for definition) paying more than 50 per cent of their income for housing, rose by 34 per cent to more than one-third."¹

The high cost of housing compared to wages in many areas of the country—particularly in metropolitan areas—is one of the main reasons for this burden.² The supply of affordable housing stock, already inadequate, has dwindled as more affluent households have competed for housing and, as a result, have driven up prices. In addition, the expiration of HUD subsidies on some buildings, the demolition of many buildings, and other factors, have caused the removal of an average of 130,000 units affordable to low-income households from the market annually between 1985 and 1991.³

As the number of low-rent units has fallen, the number of low-income renters has risen. In 1970, there was a surplus of low-rent units—7.4 million low-rent units and 6.5 million low-income renters. In 1993, the shortage of affordable housing for low-income households reached 4.7 million units.⁴ In 1993, over 900,000 households were on the waiting lists for public housing, and nearly 1.4 million households were waiting for privately-owned subsidized housing. Countless other households, which are overpaying, do not appear on lists; many housing authorities have closed their waiting lists because the need is so much greater than the supply.⁵ Homelessness, overcrowding, and unsanitary conditions have been some of the results of the loss of affordable housing. In view of this situation, community-based developers and enlightened housing authorities have been attempting to redress this growing shortfall.

Who lives in affordable housing?

Most residents of affordable family housing work. Of the six and one half million families with children below the poverty line in 1994 in the US, 64 per cent are employed.¹²

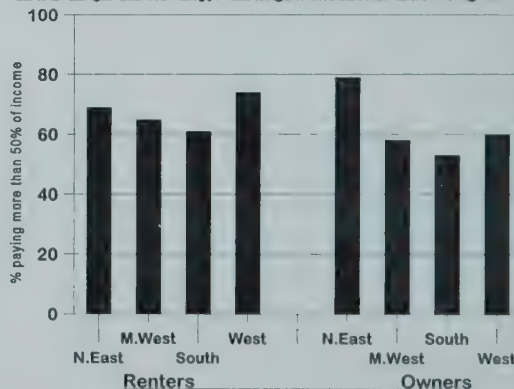


Willie Pettus

Who needs affordable housing?

A family is considered "low-income" if the household income is below 80 per cent of an area's median income (AMI), below 50 per cent is called "very-low-income", and below 25 per cent is called "extremely-low-income". In 1990, over 40 per cent or almost 20 million families with children in the US were considered low-income. Many of these families had incomes below the poverty line—\$11,522 for a family of three in 1993.⁶ In 1993, 14 per cent of all US households were in this category.⁷ For example, in Alameda County, California, (1995) the area median income was \$55,400 for a family of four. A typical family of four qualifying for affordable housing makes about \$30,000 a year—or two breadwinners each earning about \$8/hr. In 1995, rents in Oakland, California for a 3-bedroom apartment averaged \$1,100/mo.—about \$13,200/year, or 45 per cent of that family's income.⁸

Housing Cost Burdens of Renters & Homeowners Living Below the Poverty Line in the Typical Large Metro Area in each Region



Source: A Place to Call Home: The Low Income Housing Crisis in 44 Major Metropolitan Areas, Center on Budget and Policy Priorities. p.54

Typical Jobs in Contra Costa County, California

Income compared to State and Federal Classifications

VERY LOW INCOME

Below 50 per cent of area median income for a family of four.

Job Description	Annual Salary
Nurses Aide	\$11,500
Accounting Clerk	\$17,000
Legal Secretary	\$23,920
Computer Operator	\$27,036

LOW INCOME

Between 50 per cent and 80 per cent of area median income for a family of four.

Truck Driver	\$30,100
Legal Clerk	\$34,260
Deputy Sheriff	\$40,398
Firefighter	\$43,506

Source: Annual Planning Information, Contra Costa County, California, 1993

Contrary to the myth that low-income renters receive disproportional subsidies, homeowners with annual incomes over \$65,000 received over \$40 billion of Federal housing subsidies in 1989 in the form of tax deductions related to homeownership.

Only a small percentage of these families paid more than 30 per cent of their incomes for housing.⁹

Homeowners received this bonus from the government, simply because they have the privilege of owning their own home(s); yet in the early 1980s the Reagan Administration cut the HUD budget (which primarily aided lower-income renters) from about \$30 billion to about \$9 billion.¹⁰ Further cuts in housing programs proposed by Congress in 1995 will make the rent burden for poor families much worse, while the mortgage interest deduction for homeowners remains untouched.

These people often work in the communities where they live, providing goods and services for the town and region. These are relatively low paid, essential service jobs such as teachers, nurses, entry-level firemen and police officers, restaurant workers, farmworkers and mechanics.

Low-income renters

For many families with low incomes, rental housing is the only form of housing within their reach. About 37 per cent of households in the US are renters, and of these about 60 per cent, or about 19.5 million households, earn incomes at or below 80 per cent of the median income for their region.¹³ One reason that many families are paying too much rent is the lack of adequate public assistance to compensate for the market's inability to serve them. Despite the federal government's pledge in 1949 to provide a decent home and a suitable living environment for every American family, only about one-third of renter households below the poverty line receive public assistance in some form for housing.¹⁴ The total federal housing subsidy in 1989 was about \$14 billion for renters with incomes below \$20,000 a year. These households received an average housing subsidy of \$300 per month. Meanwhile, middle- and upper-income homeowners received an average of \$326 per month in mortgage interest deductions.¹⁵

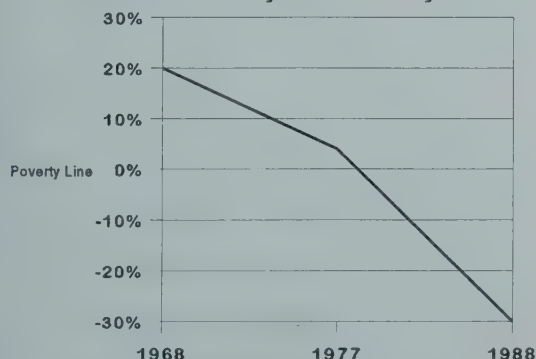
Low-income homeowners

About 19 million, or 32 per cent, of all homeowner households are low-income—they earn below 80 per cent of the median income in their region. Although only about 1.2 million, or about 6 per cent, receive any housing assistance from the government, another 17 per cent or over 3 million low-income households are paying more than 50 per cent of their income for housing.¹⁶ In most cities, most homeowners below the poverty line are paying over 30 per cent of their incomes for housing. This problem is particularly bad in major cities around the country, ranging from Boston to Miami to San Diego, which have undergone growth spurts and become magnets for more affluent households.¹⁷

In most areas, new affordable housing for low-income families is rental because it is the type of housing most affordable to households in need. However, given the opportunity, many families with low incomes would prefer owning their own homes, and there are some subsidy programs that private and non-profit developers around the country are using to make this possible. Although rental housing is typically less expensive to develop on a per unit basis than homeownership for low-income families, many communities also prefer low-income homeownership to rental housing because they perceive it as more stable, and politically less controversial.

Still, it is important to note that the financial responsibilities of homeownership can be hard for low-income families to assume—only people above a certain income level can qualify. Significantly higher subsidies—often twice as much as for rental housing—are required to make homeownership affordable for those who qualify on a long-term basis. Often the local government will make up part of the gap with a second mortgage that need not be repaid when the

**Annual Income Working Full Time at Min. Wage
In Relation to Poverty Line for Family of 3**



Someone working full time at minimum wage in 1968 was 20 per cent above the poverty line. Someone working full time at minimum wage in 1988 was 26 per cent below the poverty line.¹¹

buyer sells if the housing is kept affordable to low-income families. This action prevents speculation and maintains the stock of affordable homes. A lease-to-purchase program can make homeownership possible for first-time buyers who have trouble making a down payment. With some developers, such as Habitat for Humanity, homeowners can participate in the construction to build up "sweat equity", thereby reducing the price of the home. This can also create a sense of community among new homeowners and their neighbors who help build their own and each other's homes.

Limited equity co-operatives

Co-ops and mutual housing offer a middle ground between renting and owning that gives the resident a stake in the property, without the possibility of making a profit on the housing as a commodity. A limited-equity co-op is owned by a non-profit corporation; the residents are shareholders, each purchasing a share (like a down payment or deposit) in the co-op. The residents' monthly payments cover the operating costs and a proportional share of the mortgage. The residents earn interest on their original investment, often at a savings or money market account rate. If a resident moves out, the new resident shareholder purchases the share for the original amount plus the accrued interest. Usually, the non-profit has first right of refusal, thus ensuring that the housing remains affordable. As co-owners, residents manage the corporation's property, and engage services to ensure effective management. Co-op housing may resemble good quality rental or homeownership housing—in fact some rental developments become limited equity co-ops in later years.

"Co-housing" is a term used to describe an intentional community, a social arrangement that typically a group of homeowners may choose in order to share resources and other aspects of their life. The housing usually includes shared facilities for eating, working, and socializing; shared childcare is a big asset for working families. Sharing facilities, equipment and even meals can save families money and time.

Diversity in affordable family housing

Family structure

Single-parent families are one of the fastest growing groups in need of affordable housing. From 1980 to 1990, the number of single parents under 34 years old with children increased by almost 25 per cent. Today, nearly one-third of all families headed by women are in poverty.¹⁸ With limited sources of income and young children, these families require more than shelter. Childcare, job training and counseling services are often critical for a single parent to find and hold a job, while after school programs and children's recreational activities allow parents to work a full day.

Another family type inadequately served by the private housing market is large families. In many cities two-bedroom units are common, three-bedroom apartments are less so, and four- and five-bedroom units are virtually non-existent.¹⁹ Families are forced into overcrowded conditions until children are old enough to find their own place. Larger families may include grandparents living at home or other extended family groups. In recognition of this problem



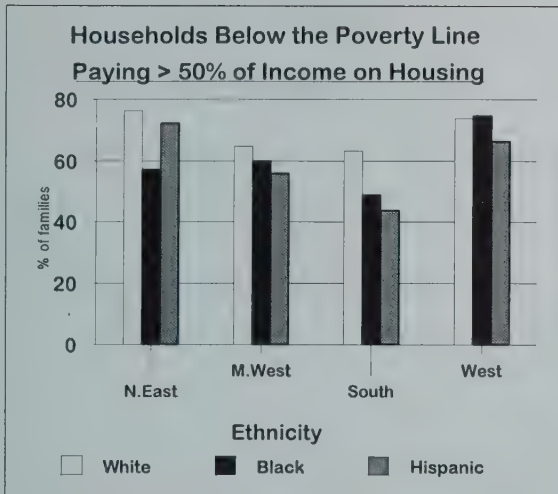
Parkside Gables, mutual housing in Stamford, Connecticut.
See p. 180
Fred George



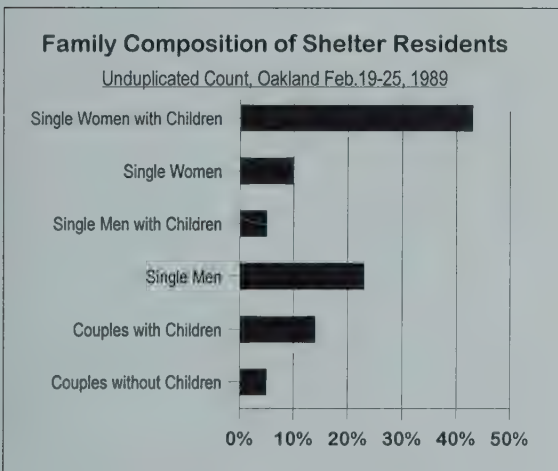
Nancy Canady and her two children Sheena and Che, resident manager of new affordable family rental housing in Oakland, California.
Michael Pyatok

What is overcrowded and substandard?

Overcrowded and substandard housing is a major problem in the United States. In 1991, it was conservatively estimated that 2.5 million low-income households lived in housing that was inadequate due to lack of plumbing, heating, appliances, or physical maintenance. Nationwide, in 1989, one of ten renter households below the poverty line lived in overcrowded conditions (more than one person per room), compared with 4 per cent of renters who were not below the poverty line; 18 per cent of households lived in physically deficient housing. Substandard housing is relatively worse in rural areas and in the South, especially in cities such as New Orleans and San Antonio. Overcrowding is a significant problem for immigrant families in metropolitan areas—in Los Angeles where there is a large population of Latino-Americans three out of every ten households live in overcrowded homes.²⁰



Source: *A Place to Call Home: The Low Income Housing Crisis in 44 Major Metropolitan Areas*, The Center on Budget & Policy. See p. 56



Family Composition of Shelter Residents		
Type	Number	Per cent
Men	660	31 per cent
Women	645	30 per cent
Children	844	39 per cent

Source: *Homelessness in Oakland: 1989 Composite Profile and Unduplicated Count*, Emergency Services Network of Alameda County.

many competitive government-assisted funding programs for affordable family housing give preference to proposals with larger units. Some of these developments are featured in the Case Studies section of the book.

Ethnicity

The housing crisis affects all households below the poverty line regardless of race. In absolute numbers Caucasians make up the majority of poor households with almost 4.2 million renter households (19 per cent) and 3.4 million homeowners (6.5 per cent) below the poverty line in 1993.²¹ Throughout the country, Caucasians with incomes below the poverty line paid more for housing than most other groups.²² However, in relation to their total populations a high percentage of African-American and Hispanic households are in poverty. Of all African-American households, 41 per cent of renters and almost 20 per cent of homeowners have incomes below the poverty line. Almost 36 per cent of Hispanic renters and over 13 per cent of homeowners are below the poverty line.²³ The increase in immigration since 1965 has significantly increased the number of minority families, especially Asian and Hispanic, seeking housing. Many of these families start below the poverty line renting in large "gateway" cities and creating a stronger demand for affordable housing in those communities. Native Americans often live in culturally inappropriate, poorly built and maintained homes on reservations managed by the Bureau of Indian Affairs, a far away agency.

Special needs

Although many people with special needs are single, families below the poverty line may also have members with disabilities or illnesses who need adequate affordable housing. Many of these families require special facilities or services such as wheelchair access or on-site social services. There is a lack of affordable housing and programs for families with special needs. This situation forces some families to be split up and many others to have members who languish indoors in inadequate facilities. Since 1991, most rental apartments and some for-sale housing built with public funds are required by law to make a percentage of the units accessible to people with disabilities. Continually changing design guidelines and regulations require designers to maintain regular contact with local agencies to determine current standards.

Homeless families

The single fastest growing population of homeless people in the US is children. In the San Francisco Bay Area alone, the State of California estimated that over 70,000 parents and children were homeless for at least one night in 1990, a 16 per cent increase over 1989. On any given night, over 20,000 people in the Bay Area compete for about 5,000 shelter beds, a refuge of last resort sometimes perceived to be more dangerous than the streets. Many people on the streets have some form of disability or substance abuse problem. These issues are not easily resolved due to a shortage of social services. Many homeless people work—up to 20 per cent work full or part time—but without the basic support systems that stable families take for granted, holding a job while homeless is extremely difficult.²⁴ Transitional housing with services is one model that begins

to address the complex needs of families working their way back into mainstream life.

Profiles of residents

In the following pages you will meet six families from around the US who demonstrate the diversity of households living in affordable housing developed by community-based developers, partly with government funds. Although each has its own story, these families stand for many others with limited incomes and housing choices. We are grateful for their willingness to be interviewed and photographed for this book.

1. "In Short Supply: The Growing Affordable Housing Gap." The Center on Budget and Policy Priorities, 1995. pp.10–12. "Rental Housing Assistance at a Crossroads: A Report to Congress on Worst Case Housing Need." Table A-4, H.U.D., March 1996.

2. "A Place to Call Home: The Low Income Housing Crisis in 44 Major Metropolitan Areas." The Center on Budget and Policy Priorities, 1992. p.1.

3. "The State of the Nation's Housing, 1994." The Joint Center for Housing Studies of Harvard University, 1994. p.16.

4. "In Short Supply" Op. Cit. p.8.

5. "A Place to Call Home" Op. Cit. p.38.

6. "In Short Supply" Op. Cit. p.8.

7. "The State of the Nation's Housing, 1994." Op. Cit. Exhibit 18, p.14.

8. City of Oakland Office of Housing and Neighborhood Development, 1995.

9. "The Housing Poster" (American Housing Survey Data). The Low Income Housing Service, 1993.

10. "Homelessness in the Bay Area." The Center for Common Cause, San Francisco, 1993. p.6.

11. Ibid. p.11.

12. US Census Data; The Statistical Abstract.

13. "The State of the Nation's Housing, 1994." Op. Cit. Exhibit 22, p.16.

14. "A Place to Call Home" Op. Cit. p.36.

15. "The Housing Poster" Op. Cit.

16. "The State of the Nation's Housing, 1994." Op. Cit. p.16. and Table A-9, p.31.

17. "A Place to Call Home" Op. Cit. p.23.

18. "Homelessness in the Bay Area." Op. Cit. p.11.

19. City of Oakland Office of Housing and Neighborhood Development, 1995.

20. "A Place to Call Home" Op. Cit. pp.25–34.

21. "The State of the Nation's Housing, 1994." Op. Cit. Exhibit 18, p.14.

22. "A Place to Call Home" Op. Cit. Table 6, p.58.

23. "The State of the Nation's Housing, 1994." Op. Cit. Exhibit 18, p.14.

24. "Homelessness in the Bay Area." Op. Cit. p.11.



CHAPTER TWO: MEET YOUR NEIGHBORS

Profiles of residents of affordable housing.

Name: Hanh and Bich Le Nguyen

Location: Oakland, California

Children: Minh (21)

Occupations:

Hanh: Maintenance supervisor, student

Bich Le: Health aide, student

HH Income Range: \$16,000–30,000/yr

Rent Range: \$430–563/mo

Unit Size: 2 BR/1 BA



Magnus Stark



Janet Delaney

Introduction: Hanh Nguyen and Bich Le live with their son Minh at Frank Mar Housing, a mixed-use development in downtown Oakland. Children yell excitedly as they run across the courtyard. The spicy smells of cooking lingered in their apartment when we met with the Nguyens on a Friday before they went to evening classes.

Hanh: "We came here from Vietnam in 1990. We were sponsored by a family in Albany. I was a pilot during the war, and trained in the US in 1969. Unfortunately we lost the war and my whole family got stuck. We suffered a lot. I was in a concentration camp for 6 years. We tried to escape several times and some of my friends were killed. I was released in 1982."

Bich Le: "When my husband was arrested at the end of the war, the airline I was working for fired me. I had to sell everything I owned, and sold candy, rice and cigarettes on the black market to support my son and my husband when he was in the camp. We were very happy to come here, although when we first arrived we had a lot of trouble. We didn't speak English. I was very afraid and I cried every day. Our sponsor lived in Albany in a very nice, quiet house in the hills. We liked them very much but we felt lonely. We were so happy when we went to Oakland Chinatown, but it was hard because of the distance. Then my husband took this job as maintenance supervisor at Frank Mar Housing and we moved here. The building is beautiful—it is modern, convenient and affordable. It's near transportation, other Asian people, and, most of all, Laney Community College."

Hanh and Bich Le take classes at Laney. Hanh: "I am taking a construction technology course so that I can become a contractor. I wish I was younger and could have started sooner—the war interrupted my studies—but it's better late than never."

Bich Le: "I work at the Vietnamese Health Promotion Project in San Francisco. I work in the Tenderloin with Vietnamese people who have limited English and are afraid to go to the hospital. Preventive health measures are a new concept for Vietnamese women, and we urge them to get checkups every year. I am studying English as a Second Language at Laney. I want to go to University to finish in public health so I can help people more with health issues."

Son Minh: "I went to Albany High School. I graduated in 1992, and went to Laney College for two years to improve my language skills. Now I am at UC Berkeley pursuing a double major in chemistry and biochemistry. I want to go to medical school or perhaps do a Ph.D. in biochemistry. I would like to teach and to help people, especially young people, with health problems."

Hanh: "We have been living here more than three years. We like it a lot, the neighborhood is quiet even though it is downtown. The residents are ethnically diverse, and everyone gets along well. The courtyard is a safe place for children to play, and we have potlucks in the community room at Christmas, Chinese New Year, and Thanksgiving. As maintenance supervisor I know almost everyone here. People like the apartments, although some people have said they wish the patios were smaller so they had more living space."

We are very glad to be here. In Vietnam we have a saying, "We can't have a good life unless we have a safe affordable place to live."

RESIDENT PROFILE

Name: Gregor Jamroski and Susan Clifford
Location: Seattle, Washington
Children: Sophia (10), Madeleine (8), Aaron (3)
Occupations:
Gregor: Artist, bookstore owner, teacher
Susan: Artist, teacher, nursing assistant
HH Income Range: \$16,000–28,000/yr
Rent: \$600/mo
Unit Size: 3 BR/2 BA



Yannis Paris



Janet Delaney

Introduction: Gregor Jamroski and Susan Clifford live with their three children at Cascade Court in Seattle. The building fits comfortably with its neighbor, the historic Stimson Mansion, in an area of older apartment buildings and tree-lined streets. The sunny courtyard was full of children playing together with parents watching and socializing. Gregor and Susan met with us after dinner.

Gregor: "Before we moved here in November 1994, we were living in a two-bedroom house in South Seattle, spending two-thirds of our income on rent. The first week we were there someone was shot and killed in our alley."

Susan: "I was working as a resident assistant for elderly people for \$7 per hour. We were just scraping by, and were on the waiting list for Cascade for two years. When our lease expired we called the management to see if there was an opening and there was! Here we are able to recover from previous years of borrowing, and we feel a lot safer. The neighborhood is a nice mix of families, single people and seniors."

Five years ago rents were doubling every year here and this area was off limits to us financially. The children go to school near here, so being able to live here affordably reduces the stress on all of us and makes family life easier.

It's great to have light and ventilation from both sides and having two bathrooms is nice so we don't have to wait in line. The play structure in the courtyard is a focal point around which families can come together and discuss things."

Gregor: "The kids love playing in the courtyard, and the young ones like to play in the planting beds. Naturally this gets management concerned."

Susan: "I'm interested in helping to create a more interactive play area for the children, like a sandbox. This would help keep them out of the landscaping. Also, if the kids can participate in replanting the beds they will be less likely to tear them up."

Gregor owns a bookstore that features 20th century literature. "When I opened the bookstore, we couldn't afford childcare for Aaron so he came with me to work every day for several years. Now he goes with Susan to work where they have a childcare program."

Susan: "I work in a program making art with seniors. Making art is very therapeutic for people and makes the places they live feel less institutional."

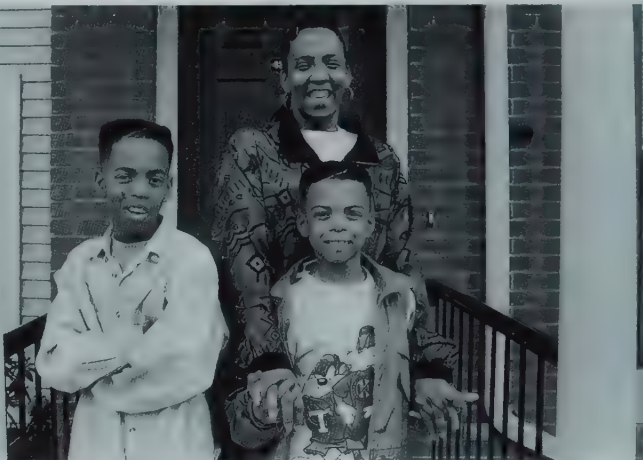
Madeleine proudly gave Gregor a Father's Day present. "I really worked very hard on this," she said. "You have to open it very carefully." As the family gathered around, Gregor opened a beautifully wrapped painting with a copper frame. "That's gorgeous, thank you so much," exclaimed Gregor. He added, "Art is a big part of our lives. We do a lot of art at home—it is very important to the children. In my own artwork I express important themes in society, such as the tension between natural systems and industrial production. I also work at a nearby school teaching art in the enrichment program, and work with Susan in the elderly art program."

Gregor and Susan agree that, "being able to move to Cascade Court was a miracle for us, and living here has made our life as a family easier and more stable."

Name: Sheryl King
Location: Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania
Children: Michael (11), Marcus (8)
Occupation: Hospital worker
HH Income Range: \$16,000–20,000/yr
Rent Range: \$400–500/mo
Unit Size: 2 BR/1.5 BA



Tim Buckman



Janet Delaney

Introduction: Sheryl King and her two boys live in Crawford Square, just a few blocks from downtown Pittsburgh, on the edge of the Hill district. The area has a rich cultural history full of jazz musicians, basketball players, and political ferment. It also has the largest concentrations of public housing in Western Pennsylvania. During the riots after the assassination of Dr Martin Luther King Jr. several blocks were burned down; Crawford Square, a mixed-income development for renters and homeowners, is built on these blocks. Sheryl spoke with us on a Friday evening after work.

Sheryl: "I grew up in the projects—it used to be safe. People looked out for each other like family, but now it's getting bad, mostly because of the drugs. There are a lot of people trying to clean things up, but I didn't want to raise my kids there. I saw the projects more as a stepping stone to get on your feet. I was able to save enough money to put down a first, last, and deposit and to move into Crawford Square.

I love it here—I have a very nice two-bedroom townhouse with a view of the City from the back porch. It was really nice that they have a program to help low-income families—I was lucky to fit in the bracket of people who qualify. At first the people in the public housing marched against Crawford Square before they knew it was partly for low-income families, but when they realized it was, they were supportive.

I work at Allegheny General Hospital in the Operating Room. I set up surgical kits for the doctors and sterilize the instruments before the operations. We see about 100 cases a day. This is my fourth job—each time I step up, and it's better for me. I

leave the house at about 5:30 every morning to go to work, and I feel secure because the street is well lit. They patrol a lot, and everyone looks out for their neighbors.

My sons go to school near here. The schools are pretty good—as long as they listen and respect the teacher they will learn. They are both on the honor roll; I'm very proud of them.

I want both my boys to go to college some day. If I have to work five jobs, that's my goal. Their dad is an excellent dad—he gets them every weekend, takes them fishing, goes to parents meetings. He went to college, and works two jobs, one at the hospital in distribution and one part time maintenance job. His boys are his life.

My neighbors are pretty diverse—there are blacks and whites here, and we all get along. My neighbor, Lisa, was white, and the kids used to go over there all the time for dinner. We both cried when she moved away. One of my other neighbors is a doctor. We don't see her much because she's so busy. Another one, her son plays pro-football. There are some elderly, and some college students.

I want my children to grow up around other cultures and learn about different types of people. That way, when they go to college they will be able to mix easily with everybody. We all have to live together and work together so we should all get along."

RESIDENT PROFILE

Name: Paula Stone
Location: Boston, Massachusetts
Children: Kenny (9)
Occupation: Homemaker/caregiver
HH Income Range: \$15,000–30,000/yr
Rent Range: \$215–400/mo
Unit Size: 2 BR/1 BA



Steve Rosenthal



Janet Delaney

Introduction: Paula Stone lives with her son Kenny at Tent City, a mixed-income rental development in the heart of Boston's historic district. Situated at the edge of Copley Square, a busy and dense commercial center, the 100-unit apartment building echoes the four-story brownstone townhouses on nearby tree-lined streets and the high rise towers across the plaza. A regional train and Metro station is across the street, while at the ground level a cafe is filled with passers-by. We met with Paula and Kenny after breakfast.

Paula: "I used to live in Marlboro, a small town outside of Boston. My mother still lives there, and she comes to visit us now and then. My other son is 20 and is in the Navy. He comes to visit when he can. It was nice and quiet in Marlboro, but I moved here to be closer to the hospitals. Kenny has brittle bone disease and needs to go for check-ups on a regular basis. Living here is great for us because we can get around more independently. With the train station across the street we are able to go downtown a lot—it's a 5-minute train ride. Right here at Tent City there's something new to do every day."

Kenny: "I like it here because there's a lot of places to go, there's a mall next door, and there's an after-school program where I can do my homework and play. The program starts at 2.30 and ends at 6. Sometimes we go on field trips to the Children's Museum or the circus."

The program is for children from families with a range of incomes. Paula: "The mixed-income population is not an issue; the kids all play together, and they don't care whether or not you have more money."

Kenny: "I take the school bus to school in Brighton every morning. I like reading and math a lot, and my favorite teacher is Maryanne. My dad comes here often—almost every day. Sometimes we go out together, and sometimes we play indoors, or work on the computer."

Paula: "My job is taking care of Kenny. I also serve as the Treasurer of the Residents Alliance, which is made up of tenants and is a liaison between the tenants and management. When there is an issue such as a rent increase, or a maintenance problem, people come to us first, so we can help make things more personalized. I enjoy visiting my neighbors, Trish Miller, who is also on the Alliance, and Ann and Domingo, an older couple. They do a lot of arts and crafts. Their apartment is full of wonderful things."

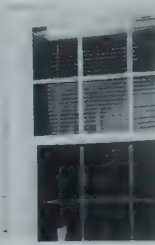
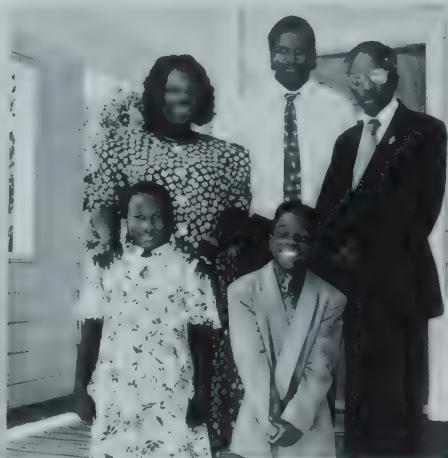
Architecturally, the building is nice. The grounds are beautiful and all the facilities are accessible for people in wheelchairs, although disabled people each have different needs. Some have to sit with their legs straight, while others have things like oxygen on the back of the chair. This usually means that they need more room to turn around in the apartment, so ideally when you are designing, you should try to leave lots of room. Also, the main doors would be more accessible if they were designed with a remote switch. This would help anyone coming home with two bags of groceries.

Life at Tent City is an experience. I love it here. I feel very lucky to be in a place that is so convenient and with so many different kinds of people."

Name: Anita and James Meniffee
Location: Chattanooga, Tennessee
Children: Olympia (9), Jarvis (7)
Occupations:
Anita: Claims processor at Blue Cross/Shield
James: Sign maker
HH Income Range: \$17,200–\$37,840/yr
Payments Range: \$350–\$500/mo
Unit Size: 3 BR/2 BA



Brian Clements



Janet Delaney

Introduction: Anita and James Meniffee and their two children live in a quiet, tree-lined neighborhood not far from the center of town. Children ride their bikes and play in the street while mothers sit and chat in the shade of front porches. The neighborhood, called Orchard Village, was built by Chattanooga Neighborhood Enterprises for families with low incomes who had been priced out of the market. We met the Meniffees as they returned from Sunday church with Anita's father.

Anita: "This home is all you could dream of. It's the first time we have owned a house. We tried several times before but we didn't have enough income to qualify. We always thought we would have to pay a lot of money that we don't have, but we are only paying \$9 more a month than we were paying in rent."

James: "Where we were living before on the Westside, it wasn't a very safe neighborhood. One night we heard a bunch of gunfire and I said to Anita, 'I can't stand it any more,' so we moved. And by the grace of God we're here."

Daughter Olympia: "We have three bedrooms, one for Jarvis and one for me. We have two full baths, one upstairs and one downstairs. There's no waiting in line any more."

Anita: "Olympia's favorite subject at school is spelling—this year she was third in the county spelling bee."

James: "We like to have barbecues in the back yard and the wrap-around porch keeps the house cooler. It can get burning hot here in the summer. The neighbors here are pretty friendly—some are single mothers and some are elderly. We look out

for each other here. Whenever I cut the grass I usually cut my neighbor's grass, because she has allergies, and it always looks funny when only one side of the lawn is cut.

We were both born and raised here in Chattanooga, a block away from each other. We met in high school, and we'll be married for nine years this September."

Anita: "Church is a big part of our lives. My father is the minister at Greater St Mary Missionary Baptist Church, and we do a lot of community work in nursing homes and with church members. We teach the children about the older people in the church so we can plant a positive seed in their minds. We don't want them to become another statistic of black children, and the best way I can think of to do that is through the church.

This location is great, because there is a park two blocks away where we can take the kids to feed the ducks, and there is a recreation center nearby. We are near three major hospitals if anything should happen. This is good for me too, because this summer I am going to go back to school and finish my nursing degree. My daughter is in Girl Scouts and my son is in Cub Scouts, so between school and work and church it's pretty hectic—there's not a lot of time to sit and rest."

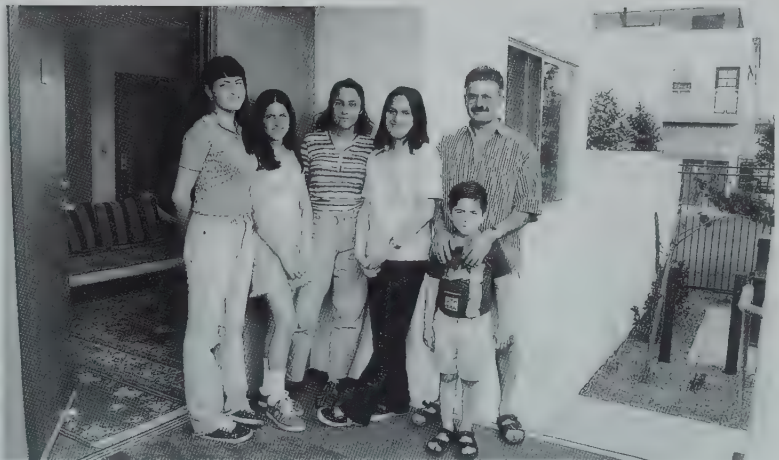
Son Jarvis had the final word. "You want to know what I like about Orchard Village? The peace and quiet!"

RESIDENT PROFILE

Name: Jose and Teresa Villafana
Location: Los Angeles, California
Children: Karen (16), Nadia (14),
Nathalie (12), Erik (6)
Occupations:
Jose: Construction worker
Teresa: Homemaker/seamstress
HH Income Range: \$12,600–35,100/yr
Rent: \$525/mo
Unit Size: 4 BR/2 BA



Marvin Rand



Janet Delaney

Introduction: Jose and Teresa Villafana live with their four children in Villa Esperanza, a new apartment building on a quiet side street in South Central Los Angeles. The housing was developed by Esperanza Community Housing Corporation who, in partnership with the Los Angeles Community Design Center, purchased the site (originally slated for a sweat-shop) to build 33 affordable apartments, with childcare services, and a neighborhood center. The apartments face an interior courtyard where children play. We met the Villafanas after Jose came home from work, before the family went to a community meeting.

Jose is a construction worker, who often spends days away from home with his crew, building gas stations, car washes and convenience stores.

Jose: "It's hard work—recently I've had to get up at 4 am to drive to San Diego. I go wherever the job is.

We heard about Villa Esperanza at San Vicente Church one Sunday. There was also a banner up at the site. We were living in the neighborhood in a two-bedroom house—all the kids in one room. We applied and were accepted. I feel like we won the lottery!"

Teresa works at home. Her industrial sewing machine sits in a corner of the master bedroom.

Teresa: "Before Erik was born I worked in a sewing shop. Now I look after Erik, and take in sewing. Most of the shops pay 50 cents a skirt, so it's hard to earn more than \$12–14/day. One lady pays \$50 a day—I like to work for her. I prefer working at home, because I can be here for the children. Erik likes to run out and play in the courtyard with his friends. He also goes to the pre-school classes at the on-site daycare center."

Twelve-year-old Nathalie: "Sometimes I go to the center for after-school classes on the computer, and do my homework. I like it here. I have lots of friends, and my school is two blocks away. Where we lived before we were really crowded. I had to share a room with my two sisters. Now we have a lot more room. My mom is a lot happier and my dad is really proud."

Jose: "It's pretty safe here, although in the beginning people were jumping over the fences and stealing things. We had to make the fences higher. We have regular community meetings to discuss issues like security, or noise. There are a lot of rules here. They are very strict about keeping things clean, and we like that."

Nathalie: "Sometimes if the play areas are left messy they make the kids go out and clean them up. On holidays like Christmas we have parties in the courtyard. People here are from different countries like El Salvador, Guatemala, Ecuador and they bring dishes of the different food from their countries. Most of the people here are from the neighborhood, so many of them we knew before. But where we lived before we didn't go out much, because there were lots of gangs. Here I feel safe."

For Jose, the safety of the courtyard housing is a big plus. "I have to go away to work for days at a time, and I feel good that my family is safe here. We all feel very lucky to be able to live here."



PART TWO: FACTORS INFLUENCING AFFORDABLE FAMILY HOUSING

CHAPTER THREE:

COMMUNITY NEEDS AND CONTEXT

Good affordable housing is closely related to good community planning. As part of their social mission to improve the livability of their community, non-profit and government housing agencies should become involved in long-term community planning in addition to single-project development.

PLAN PARTICIPATION

Effective and meaningful community plans require the participation of diverse people and groups. This can extend the timetable for achieving consensus. However, consensus reached through the community planning process hopefully builds political support for affordable housing as a featured element in a community plan.

Community planning requires the following components:

- Housing needs assessment
- Goals and strategies
- Evaluation of present context
- Community vision

Housing needs assessment

The community planning process begins with an assessment of community needs. Census information, demographic trend projections, evaluation of the existing housing stock, and the experiences of family service agencies all contribute toward the development of a needs assessment. The location, rent, and sales price of existing housing and its correspondence with the income of current or future residents establishes the type of "affordability gap" that exists.

Based on this analysis, the needs assessment then quantifies how many units of what size and what rent or sales level would best meet the community's present and future needs.

Goals and strategies

After agreeing on housing needs, short and long term goals and priorities must be set. For example, in response to a deteriorating building stock, a community could set as its primary goal the rehabilitation of 150 units of family housing over a ten-year period, targeting them for households below 60 per cent of median income. In response to projected population growth due to employment growth, a second priority goal might be the construction of 100 new units for sale to low- to moderate-income households over ten years.

Improving the overall quality of residential life requires more than just improving housing. A community plan should also include goals concerning local industry and small business, schools, employment opportunities, public safety, and cultural and recreational facilities.

Once goals and priorities are established, strategies for carrying out the goals should be identified. Meeting affordable housing goals in existing communities almost always requires strategies for finding funds and creating incentives for the improvement of the existing housing stock, and for identifying sites and financing for new construction.

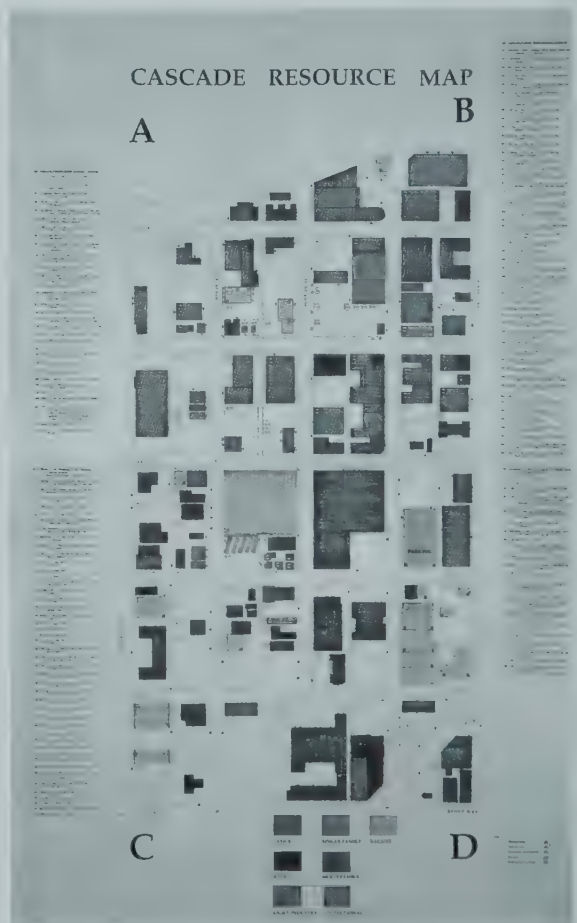
Evaluation of present context

A community plan represents an opportunity for participants to discuss and describe their perceptions of the major assets and liabilities of their existing environment. This process begins with the documentation of the existing neighborhood context using photographs, maps, and narrative. This information then becomes the basis for



Local residents formed a planning group and worked with Michael Pyatok and architecture students at the University of Washington to study the Cascade neighborhood in Seattle, Washington.

Michael Pyatok



One product of the Cascade neighborhood study, a Community Resource Map.



New scattered site public housing fits in well with historic housing, Charleston, South Carolina. See p. 208

Richard Bradfield



Mission Bay in San Francisco is a largely abandoned industrial area. Many neighborhood plans have been created for this valuable property.

Tom Jones



A vision of neighborhood with housing, civic, and commercial uses, one result of community planning workshops, Emeryville, California.

Michael Pyatok

community workshops focused on how the environment is currently serving the needs of the community.

Drawing on their own experiences, participants in the planning process can be very articulate with respect to the ways the buildings, streets, public spaces, institutions, traffic, transportation systems, and natural features affect life in the community. They can also express the social and cultural significance of places and buildings within the community which may not necessarily be evident to outsiders.

The analysis of the built environment of the community looks not just at the physical features and expression of the community, but also at underlying social and economic factors that affect the uses and appearances of buildings and places in the community. Sometimes the forms and conditions of structures in a community create the appearance of prosperity or security, while masking actual social and economic conditions. Conversely, the facades of buildings may appear weathered or undistinguished, but the economic health and vitality of the community may be strong.

Community vision

The final stage in the planning process is the generation of a comprehensive vision for the future of the community. The vision takes the form of a plan which uses maps, diagrams, and before-and-after sketches which convey the physical changes desired by the community. The text of the community plan should articulate how physical improvements are linked to social and economic improvements in achieving desired goals. The amount and type of resources and the required governmental actions necessary to implement the plan should be clearly delineated. A community vision and plan should illustrate and explain the interactive relationships between affordable housing preservation and development activities and other public and private improvements. Affordable housing activities undertaken within the framework of such a shared vision is more likely to be positively received by both its residents and the whole community.

The strong relationship between community planning and successful affordable housing has been recognized by groups across the political spectrum. This was demonstrated by the broad support HUD received for their 1994 requirement that communities who solicit HUD financial support must have a consolidated plan which establishes long range needs and identifies appropriate contexts for affordable housing.

COMMUNITY PLANNING IN DIVERSE CONTEXTS

The participatory, local community planning as outlined above is peculiarly North American. One significant result of this decentralized, locally initiated process is a diversity of plans and a related diversity of affordable housing design.

The diversity of architecture evident in the most recent generation of affordable housing also reveals a strong response to the diversity of climates, materials, building traditions, dwelling types, and street and open space patterns found throughout the nation.

At the same time, there are broad similarities in site planning approaches and housing typologies which are shared by affordable housing developments in similar types of communities. Many American communities face similar underlying social and economic conditions, and congruities of social and economic need unite communities that differ geographically and physically. For example, when considering the forces affecting a community and its potential strategy for improving itself, high-density Harlem and low-density Watts have more in common with one another than Harlem has in common with suburban New York or Watts has with rural California.

There are also congruities of physical forms and land-use patterns that broadly define communities as being either part of a city, a suburb, a town, or a rural area. In broad terms, the divisions that exist between city, suburb, and country town correspond to both social and land-use identities which heavily influence affordable housing activity. Community based architects, developers, and planners must be aware of the particular issues they may face that are specific to the communities in which they work.

The following sections examine in greater detail the common challenges and opportunities facing contemporary sponsors and designers of affordable housing based upon their work in one of the following three types of American communities:

- Older urban neighborhoods
- Suburbs and small towns
- Rural areas

OLDER URBAN NEIGHBORHOODS

Most American cities have residential and mixed-use neighborhoods that are facing decline. The loss of manufacturing jobs in or near these neighborhoods contributes to unemployment and lower incomes among residents. This loss is often coupled with general economic disinvestment and deferred maintenance or abandonment of privately held buildings. In various proportions, groups or blocks of housing require renovation, and small or large vacant tracts of land require redevelopment.

The effort to restore and revitalize older urban neighborhoods requires a strategy for one or more of the following types of housing activities:

- Renewal of older housing
- New housing infill
- Multiple development co-ordination
- New district development
- Urban design co-ordination



Single-family homes for first-time buyers at Lyton Park Place, Minneapolis, Minnesota.
See p. 152

Franz Hall



Duplex and triplex townhouses at Hyde Square Co-op, Dorchester, Massachusetts.
See p. 176

Peter Vanderwarker



Mixed-income high-density rental housing, Cascade Court, Seattle, Washington.
See p. 116

Yannis Paris



Dilapidated historic housing before renovation, Regent Terrace, Philadelphia, Pennsylvania. See p. 239

Howard Brunner



After renovation, Regent Terrace is a community of affordable family housing. Eric Mitchell

Renewal of older housing

Community plans place a high priority on the rehabilitation of existing housing as a first step in halting physical and social decline. Housing preservation and restoration activities may range from upgrading building systems and repairing facades and roofs, to more drastic rehabilitation which involves the reconfiguration of the rooms.

The preservation and revitalization of architecturally significant, historic structures is another potential activity in older urban neighborhoods. Historic preservation is often eligible for financial resources that are not available for non-historic rehabilitation work. Historic preservation can also reinvigorate local pride and increase outside interest in the community.

New housing infill

When deterioration and abandonment become prevalent, there is a likely pattern of arson and vandalism that may lead to demolition activity. Razed structures are replaced by untended vacant lots that further degrade a community. Therefore, selective in-fill development of vacant parcels is a companion strategy in these types of communities.

Inserting new structures into the existing fabric to achieve a balance between the architectural character of the surrounding buildings and the contemporary spatial needs of families is a challenge. Attempting to insert developments that are at different densities to the adjacent structures requires design sensitivity.

Occasionally there is an opportunity or an economic necessity to develop several scattered sites within the community simultaneously. Balancing the architectural goal to develop each site in response to its surroundings with the economic goal for efficient, replicable unit plans raises another set of challenges.

Multiple development co-ordination

New affordable housing, public amenities, and complementary non-residential uses may all be necessary to attract the general reinvestment and resettlement that are desired for older urban neighborhoods. Determining

which sites and facilities should be developed first may be crucial to generate momentum toward the final development goals. Affordable housing is often chosen to play the initiating role for community improvements because it may require less public investment and lead time to develop than other public improvements.

Attempts to reinvigorate older urban neighborhoods by attracting new residents can create tension regarding the appropriate balance between affordable housing and market-rate housing and between the needs of existing residents and the expected benefits and impact of new residents. Plans for these types of neighborhoods must resolve this tension in order to proceed.

New district development

In addition to declining neighborhoods, many cities contain large tracts of under-utilized land which offer an opportunity to plan and develop new neighborhoods. Such tracts may have been industrial or railyard districts or former military bases, which have been ignored by market-rate developers. These potential new urban districts typically contain environmental hazards, insufficient infrastructure, inadequate access, or other impediments to development that require a substantial commitment of initial financing to mitigate or overcome.

Characteristically, the development or redevelopment of new districts requires pioneers; affordable housing developers and their residents may be more willing than market-rate developers in such urban areas.

City officials or citizens often expect new neighborhoods to provide a range of housing types and affordability. This imperative may derive from a goal to balance housing affordability and jobs. Environmentalists and housing advocates have a common interest in maximizing affordable housing in new urban districts served by existing mass transit and infrastructure as an alternative to regional sprawl, and freeway dependency.

Urban design co-ordination

Multiple urban sites and new districts represent unusual opportunities for creating diverse public and private realms and for integrating many building types and sizes within a unifying plan.

Within an overall urban design plan for a revitalized new neighborhood, there are alternate approaches to the incorporation of affordable housing. One strategy for incorporation is the prior designation of certain sites coupled with site-specific financing. A second strategy is the requirement that each site or phase in the plan set aside a certain percentage of the units in each building as affordable units. Under this strategy, market-rate and below-market-rate units are constructed and financed together.

Under either approach overall planning and design guidelines can be adopted, which make affordable housing indistinguishable from market-rate housing.

SUBURBS AND SMALL TOWNS

Suburbs and small towns have been homes to more North Americans than center cities since the early 1960s. Seen once as a solution to urban housing ills, suburbs in particular have existed long enough to generate their own housing problems.

Although suburbs and small towns mirror some of the same social and physical problems as many center cities, they often lack the political or financial resources to address them. Unlike cities, they also tend to lack a wide range of housing types, and they often lack inhabitants with widely varying incomes and cultural backgrounds.

In suburbs and small towns, affordable housing sponsors face the following challenges:

- Predominance of the single-family house
- Lack of good multi-family models
- Reduced public realm
- Neighborhood acceptance

Predominance of the single-family house

In post-war suburbs, development was largely predicated on the idea that the single-family detached house on a generous lot was the most acceptable model for residential life. The strict separation of residential districts from other uses was another norm for this period of suburban settlement. Although initially touted as an economical way to house America's returning veterans, this settlement model has become increasingly costly both to the consumer and to the environment.

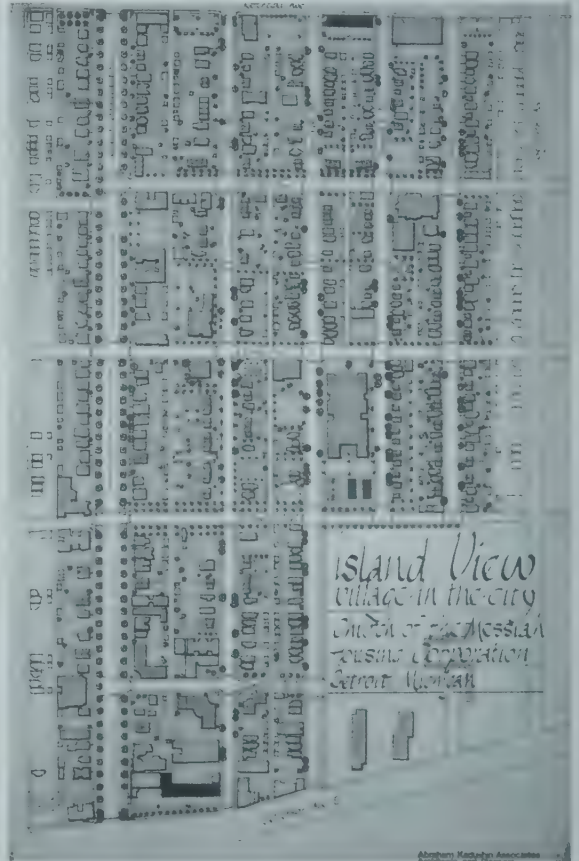
Lack of multi-family models

The movement to provide new and less expensive models for suburban and small town residential development originated among market-rate developers. Many of them



Infill housing matches the local context, Field Street, Detroit, Michigan. See p. 154

Kadushin



Field Street is part of a neighborhood plan called Island View, Detroit, Michigan.

See p. 154

Kadushin

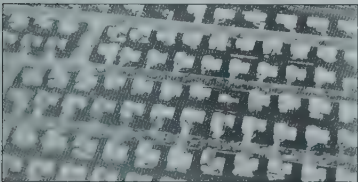


A mix of new construction, rehab, market-rate and affordable housing helps make the Randolph Neighborhood in Richmond, Virginia a diverse and balanced community. See p. 210

Tom Bernard



The American Dream—a single family detached home in the suburbs.



The American reality—the sameness and anonymity of suburbia.



Less costly, higher density alternatives to single-family homes can be designed to appear friendly and less dense in suburban communities. Townhouses at 25 units per acre, Tower Apartments, Rohnert Park, California. See p. 90

Michael Pyatok

recognized that the cost of constructing new homes under the old pattern was increasing more rapidly than household income.

Many towns and suburbs have responded to pressure from developers to reduce housing costs by allowing greater housing density, smaller lots, and attached or clustered housing units in some areas. Unfortunately, much of the higher-density housing constructed between 1950 and the present is seen as unattractive and undesirable. Bulky buildings, motel layouts, and cheap materials contributed to this problem, as did the fact that many communities allowed this type of housing in less desirable areas such as near industrial areas, freeways, and fringe areas.

This post-war multi-family housing stock often has none of the architectural character or locational advantages of older apartments built for the Depression-era middle class. As a result, a primary task for suburban and small town affordable housing sponsors has been to create a new model for higher-density housing.

REDUCED PUBLIC REALM

The suburban and romantic small town ideal derives from a largely upper-class concept of a community as a picturesque enclave of individual residences existing within nature. This ideal manifested itself in the characteristic front lawns, which in older, more affluent suburbs appear to merge together to form a park-like setting between the street and the individual homes. The front lawns originally defined a new kind of expansive, soft public realm that contrasted with the more contained, harder public realm of city streets and plazas.

Over time this idealized public realm has shrunk in size and diminished in landscaping. This is especially true in high growth areas with soaring land prices where individual homes have grown as lots and front yards have shrunk, and where the expanses of concrete paving and garage doors have become the dominant visual features.

The emergence of gated communities and the popularity of cul-de-sac street patterns has also led to more fragmentation and social isolation within newer suburbs, and further reduced the pleasure and efficacy of pedestrian life.

The physical and social isolation characteristic of many residential suburbs and their sprawl has spawned a movement to create an alternative model. Calling itself "the new urbanism", this movement harks back to 19th and early 20th century small towns and suburbs. The new urbanists are united in a desire to develop new residential community models that contain greater housing variety and a vital public realm. A few privately developed communities such as Seaside, Florida, and The Kentlands, Maryland, demonstrate some of the new urbanists' planning and design concepts. The aesthetic results and market successes of these communities have attracted positive media attention.

If more market-rate developers adopt some of the new urbanist approaches, the physical character of new

developments will improve. But on their own, market-rate developers will still need public financial subsidies if they are to create significant numbers of affordable housing units in these new communities.

NEIGHBORHOOD ACCEPTANCE

Affordable housing sponsors value social connections and strive to promote a positive sense of community among their residents. In this regard they are pro-community. But the housing they construct or the people who will live in it are often seen as a threat to a community. Trying to develop affordable housing in a multi-family development poses a significant challenge to suburban and small town sponsors. People who live in conventional detached housing often view those who live in other types of residential structures as less desirable neighbors.

Homeowners often view renters as less stable neighbors who will bring crime and lower property values to their neighborhood. These stereotypes can be challenged by developers and public officials through focused public education efforts that illustrate the profiles of potential qualifying residents of affordable housing. As existing residents actually meet people in the neighborhood who need affordable housing, and understand their income levels, job descriptions, and the schools their children attend they realize that these people are their neighbors. Some homeowners forget that they once were renters, or that they too once struggled to find a downpayment.

"Subsidized housing" raises strong negative connotations about poorly designed, poorly managed "projects" filled with people who don't work. Developers and managers of well-designed and well-managed affordable housing often must take community members on tours of their existing developments to see the quality of the environment, meet residents, and talk to neighbors who are willing to testify that living next to such affordable housing does not lower property values.

In some regions, organizations that advocate on behalf of non-profit developers (such as Non-profit Housing Development of Northern California) are developing community acceptance campaigns that strive to educate people in the ways described above.

Good design cannot completely eliminate fears of other kinds of people, but the promotion of high quality design standards in these communities should at least remove design as a contentious issue and allow other opinions and concerns to be aired.

RURAL AREAS

A new wave of American residential settlement is occurring in some rural areas. The 1990 census projects faster growth in rural areas than in cities, towns, and suburbs. Some of this growth is spurred on by new manufacturing concerns locating in these areas where land and labor are cheaper. At the same time, changes in grazing, mining, forestry, and



Six-unit buildings house mixed-income condominiums at Battle Road Farm, Lincoln, Massachusetts. See p. 166

Lucy Chen

agricultural operations are leading to job losses and lower wages for existing rural residents. Rural areas contain some of the greatest extremes of wealth and poverty in America.

The challenges for rural affordable housing developers include:

- Restrictions on density
- Providing appropriate models

Restrictions on density

Separated both by income and often by great spaces, rural residents and the rural housing market share the primacy of the house on its own plot of land, with its own front and back door. This housing type is promoted by land-use regulations which often require very large lots, from one unit per acre to 40 or more acres per unit, in an attempt to preserve rural character. Although these regulations may have originally been intended to protect and promote small farmsteads, in many cases small farms are not viable and the large plots are used as retreats for wealthy households.

Rural requirements for large lots derive in part from notions of rural livelihood which do not reflect the reality of existence for large sectors of the rural population. They may also relate to the dependency on ground water and the requirement for septic fields, which are restraints that may vary widely within the same region.

Providing appropriate models

The predominance of detached buildings suggests a need for affordable housing in many rural areas. Yet the pressure for detached buildings must be reconciled with the pressure for economy of construction. Since rural housing development will usually stand out against a natural or agrarian landscape, the image of the housing as seen from a distance will be of substantial concern. One alternative rural site plan model is buildings which appear to be single residences but actually contain several units. This model is particularly appropriate



Affordable family rental apartments are woven into a pecan orchard at Dermott Villas, Dermott, Arkansas. See p. 247

Timothy Hursley



OPAL Commons, a rural mixed-income co-housing community on Orcas Island, Washington. See p. 68

Ron Glasset

in locations where large, older homes and agricultural buildings are common, and can provide sources of architectural context.

A second rural model is clustered housing, which is not a prevalent rural model but which is common in other parts of the world. Clustered housing conveys a strong social as well as physical cohesion by defining exterior common spaces and creating a recognizable form much like a village in the larger landscape. Clustering achieves more economical housing and closer social ties; it also accomplishes the preservation of large tracts of agricultural land or open space that might otherwise be subdivided.

Under either model, rural developments should be linked to open space preservation as an alternative to large-lot subdivisions. The co-existence of affordable housing with agricultural, recreational, and even wildlife preserve uses is possible with careful community planning and site design.

COMMON GOALS IN ALL COMMUNITIES

Common to all three categories of communities is a uniform goal for affordable family housing to be integral to the larger vision and plan for the community. In some instances it will be expected to stand out as a symbol of change and an image of a better future. In other instances it will be expected to fit in, as a complement to the present and bridge to the past. Each community has the right and obligation to help define the role that affordable housing should play within a community plan.

Other factors shape the final design of the development, but the ultimate measure of the success of the design for the community will be the degree to which it fulfills its expectations. Outsiders may appreciate architectural quality and value design awards, but true design excellence comes from meeting the community's needs and enhancing the neighborhood in the eyes and hearts of its residents.



CHAPTER FOUR:
POLICY, FINANCE, AND REGULATIONS

Grand community plans may excite the imagination, but making them become real depends upon the co-ordinated support of public policy, financial practices, and local land-use regulations.

DESIGN QUALITY AND REGULATIONS

Where local and state agencies have co-ordinated their programs, resources, and approval procedures to promote and reward good design, project sponsors have a positive environment in which to create their residential development. By contrast, talented architects and experienced non-profit sponsors have been frustrated, if not defeated, when they have undertaken projects in communities that have no public policy support for good design, limited or capped financial resources, and planning and zoning rules that promote inappropriate housing models.

Taken together, the rules, restrictions, and criteria of each agency or institution involved become major determinants of the design of affordable housing. The challenge to committed architects and sponsors is to have an impact on the regulators long before they have to comply with the regulations.

PUBLIC POLICY AGENCIES

Public affordable housing policies adopted by federal, state, and local governments and agencies are the legal basis for all housing programs. Housing programs are then fashioned and implemented in response to general policies. Both at the level of the general policy, and in the details of funding programs, there are opportunities to include language and procedures that would promote higher construction quality and better design.

One or more of the following entities may be involved in generating policies and programs which govern affordable housing developments:

- HUD
- State and local governments
- Tax credit allocation committees

HUD

The agency with the greatest influence on affordable housing design is the federal Department of Housing and Urban Development, HUD, which is responsible for carrying out the housing programs that are enacted and approved by the Congress and the President. Affordable housing funding programs are constantly being added, modified, and deleted as part of the political process in Washington, DC, a situation of primary concern to affordable housing sponsors and advocates.

HUD oversees the Community Development Block Grant (CDBG) program which allocates yearly grants based on a congressional formula. CDBG awards to communities are a major though shrinking source of affordable housing funds. HUD also operates its own programs which make direct project grants in response to competitive individual applications by a project sponsor, or by a locality. Cuts in these programs projected over the next several years are a result of a shift in policy made by the President and Congress and carried out by HUD.



San Francisco City Hall, one source of political and financial support for affordable family housing.

Tom Jones



HUD family housing built in the 1950s to minimum standards, Oakland, California.

Willie Pettus

CONSOLIDATED PLAN for Housing & Community Development

July 1, 1995 - June 30, 2000



May 16, 1995

City of Oakland
Office of Housing and
Neighborhood Development

A consolidated plan, an essential strategy for local government to support affordable family housing.

When making direct grants, HUD administers both policy and funds; costs and designs are controlled through their formulas and regulations. These regulations have always been a challenge for designers to decipher and to apply.



Housing for formerly homeless single mothers and children, developed with state funding assistance, West HELP, Greenburgh, NY. See p. 172

Jack Pottle



New community room and library at 555 Ellis Street, San Francisco, California. See p. 108

John F. Martin

HUD has lifted some of its strict cost control measures for housing, which were based on sometimes erroneous assumptions regarding the cost-effectiveness of standardized, box-like buildings. At the level of the district offices, HUD now appears to be more concerned with design than in the past. HUD and some other federal agencies like the Federal National Mortgage Agency (FNMA) conduct design awards programs. However, some project sponsors and their architects affirm that considerable energy is still required to get better buildings when working with federal policy guidelines.

State and local governments

Most states require localities to adopt some form of local housing policy that identifies affordable housing needs and indicates how their fair share of those housing needs will be met. The policy should address both unit production and rehabilitation goals, and should indicate how the local zoning and the availability of sites will accommodate these goals. Any locality that is seeking federal funds to support its affordable housing programs must now generate a local consolidated plan which contains this information plus financial strategies for achieving affordable housing goals. These policies should reinforce or complement one another.

At the local and state level, project sponsors have a better opportunity to influence policies and their related programs so that they recognize and support well-designed buildings. For example, when state agencies and local government make financial awards, they can require or recognize the inclusion of supportive services and amenities in affordable housing, the provision of a variety of housing unit types, and a commitment to high quality materials and design.

Municipalities and states can create higher design standards than federal ones. When both federal and non-federal funds are used, HUD may accept the higher standards as a legal basis for raising cost allowances. In one case HUD told a project sponsor that an elevator was not needed for a two-story senior development. When the locality showed HUD that its own housing policy required elevators for any seniors living above grade, HUD relented and funded the elevator.

Tax credit allocation committees

The federal government has codified the Federal Tax Credit for Low Income Housing, a funding program which gives investors in affordable housing an attractive tax break. Although the financial program is an adjunct to the federal tax code, state tax credit allocation committees select which developments are awarded funds. Many of the better state tax credit allocation agencies make their awards based upon some form of a scoring, or point system for evaluating projects which are applying at the same time. Several states have had very successful experiences by giving extra points to family housing which contains features that contribute to better quality, livability, and design.

For example, in California, the point system rewards developments with bigger units and more bedrooms for families, ample resident community rooms, and designated children's play space and equipment. Since sponsors competing for tax credits know that the inclusion of these features will enhance their chances to receive funding, the state supports better design through its program.

At all levels of public policy, incentives and requirements for more durable and more livable family housing improve the general level of project applications for funding and affordable housing design quality.

FINANCIAL AGENCIES

With supportive public policy in place, adequate and timely public financial assistance is the next critical factor in obtaining good design. Public agencies which are the primary source of affordable housing funds have an opportunity and a responsibility to support good local design at several points in the development of a project.

Other funders should share and support high design standards as well. Since most affordable housing depends upon multiple sources of funds, the interaction among the following potential funders is important:



Playground at Tuscany Villas, Davis, California. See p. 78

Jane Lidz

- Local government agencies
- Redevelopment agencies
- Private foundations
- Private lenders

Local government agencies

Local finance agencies which administer CDBG and HOME funds can incorporate criteria reflecting design quality into their standards for lending or granting local funds, and they should be committed to supplement state and federal financing to provide adequate development budgets for superior design.

Their on-going public financial support for good design should also include local programs that give local housing producers grants or deferred loans for retaining architects in the predevelopment stage of a project. These same agencies can assist non-profits by financing site feasibility studies so that several alternative sites or schemes can be evaluated before a project site is selected.

Some local public funds should also be committed to support affordable housing education programs for both sponsors and citizens. Evaluating and illustrating the positive benefits of good design, and examining the effect of the local codes and approval process on cost and design are important research and discussion components of public education.

Redevelopment agencies

In this era, the source of local funds is severely limited. In many jurisdictions the sole or primary source of local financing is the local redevelopment agency. Redevelopment agencies use tax exempt revenue from existing properties combined with bonds and other public debt to raise housing funds.

In addition to being a source of project funds, redevelopment agencies also have the statutory authority to acquire and set aside sites, adopt urban design guidelines, conduct architectural review and make final project approvals. The integration of all this activity in one agency creates an opportunity and a responsibility to support good design consistently throughout its programs.

In some cities, additional funds have been raised for affordable housing through programs in which developers of hotels, high-rise offices, and other private facilities pay a housing mitigation fee linked to the demand for affordable housing created by their anticipated workforce. The decline of office construction and the economic downturn of the 1990s has weakened community's ability to enact such provisions, but they should be considered for the future. Such programs may be part of the activities of a redevelopment agency, or may be centered in some other agency.

The constant need to stabilize and expand sources of local revenue for housing requires advocacy and creative thinking. Those concerned about design quality should participate in or support these efforts.

Private foundations

While most affordable housing is primarily dependent on low interest loans or grants provided by public agencies, private financing of some kind is typically needed as well. Private financial resources must be available and committed to augment public funds in achieving good design.

Private foundation grants have played a valuable role in providing such additional funds, which project sponsors have used to improve building quality and to finance specific



Daycare center at Sarah P. Huntington House, New York City. See p. 244 *Rody Jean-Luis*



Bankers, funders, and elected officials at a grand opening for new affordable housing, San Francisco, California.

A.N.D.

amenities that would not have been achieved with only public funds. The commitment on the part of some investors to good design has led them to mount their own education campaigns directed to other financial investors and government agencies.

National equity investors and funders such as the Local Initiatives Support Corporation (LISC) and the Enterprise Foundation have also undertaken programs to help local officials and non-profit sponsors learn how to get better quality developments, through workshops, conferences, and continuing education programs. Housing advocates hope that other regional and local foundations will become involved in this type of support.

Private lenders

Most family affordable housing also depends on private banks or savings and loans to provide construction financing or permanent financing. Private banks and savings and loans develop their own risk criteria for lending, but some recognize and factor into their evaluations the long-term value of affordable housing which includes beneficial amenities and is well designed.

One example of a lender's program that recognizes the value of design quality is the AHP (Affordable Housing Program) sponsored by the Federal Home Loan Bank. This program offers deferred grants and loans to applicants through periodic competitive rounds. While their primary criteria for participating in developments is to help reduce debt burdens that would otherwise make projects infeasible, they make their awards using criteria which also include other factors. They are explicitly interested in assisting developments which provide amenities and other features and resident programs that increase livability, contribute to a stronger sense of community, and promote opportunities for individual and family development.

PLANNING REGULATIONS AND PROCEDURES

The next and perhaps most complex hurdle that project sponsors face is their own local planning code and planning approval process. In the US, each city, town, or county

adopts its own planning code. Planning codes are co-ordinated to land-use maps, which subdivide the jurisdiction into zones designated by what types of uses are allowed within each zone (residential, commercial, manufacturing). Planning includes the on-going act of designating zones and determining what uses, heights, densities, parking, and other requirements pertain to them.

Prior to the early 1900s, there was no zoning as we know it today; market forces dictated what was built where. In one of the earliest legal tests of zoning, the courts determined that communities did have the right to regulate land use for the common welfare, and to protect the rights of each property owner against the possibility of deleterious uses on adjacent properties.

Court decisions in the 1920s supported the legal rights of communities to adopt zoning restrictions, and explicitly supported the separation of single-family housing from other uses. The formal separation of single-family from multi-family housing, freestanding houses from row houses and apartments began with that decision, and, combined with automobile use, accelerated the development of the suburban landscape we have inherited today.

The influences of zoning districts and other planning conditions on any development are enormous, and affordable housing in particular will be subject to or dependent on one or more of the following:

- Conventional planning code regulations
- Planned unit development regulations
- Inclusionary zoning
- Affordable housing incentives
- Planning approval process

Conventional planning code regulations

Since the 1920s, local zoning ordinances have evolved under the influence of planning theory, lobbying, and advocacy to become elaborate regulations. Many residential zoning ordinances and planning codes now regulate: the dimensions of building lots, the number and type of units



A new single-family housing development built with reduced street widths, setbacks, and parking regulations, setting new standards. Benson Glen, Renton, Washington. See p. 70

Dick Springgate

on the lots, the amount of land covered by any building, the height of buildings, the spaces between buildings and adjacent structures or lot lines, the minimum amount of open space per unit, and the minimum number of parking spaces.

Although planning codes are ostensibly established to promote new development that reflects community standards, planning codes are often a patchwork of regulations designed more to prevent the bad than to encourage the good. Regulations such as the placement of buildings on their sites with equal setbacks from neighboring structures were intended to produce compatibility, but they actually promoted the boxlike, motel-type apartment buildings typical of the 1950s through 1970s, when applied to large lots.

These types of buildings have contributed to a negative perception of higher density housing in many communities as well as a distrust of planning and zoning documents and procedures.

Planned unit development regulations

Partially in response to the need for a more flexible approach to planning, and to get more control over architectural design features, many communities adopted planned unit development (PUD) zoning in the 1960s. Under the PUD approach, larger sites could be developed at higher densities and conventional setback and other location regulations might be reduced, in exchange for a better overall design.

The PUD process depends on project sponsors, professional planners, and community groups being clear and reasonable about the various tradeoffs that can and should be made. When PUD zoning is used developers are encouraged to

identify natural or historical features that should be preserved as part of a development. They may also be encouraged to achieve greater affordability than conventional detached construction might allow, while still producing a desirable residential environment.

Implicit in much of PUD zoning are two assumptions. One is that developers need to be given an incentive such as a density bonus so they will elect to use the PUD approach. The cost savings and superior design that may result from PUD zoning should motivate the sponsor to expend the often higher design fees and longer approval process associated with the PUD approach.

The second assumption is that the community will get some public benefit from the resulting design, with the possibility that the lower development costs per unit of many PUD plans will be passed on to the housing consumer.

While many PUD developments have produced good design, and the approach is favored by many planners, their housing prices and rents have not been substantially lower unless required to be so by law.

Inclusionary zoning

In the 1980s beginning in New Jersey and then Southern California, communities were legally or morally challenged to be more proactive in obtaining affordable housing as a part of new market-rate development. This led to the adoption of inclusionary zoning, by which communities required a certain percentage of all new units to be affordable, often in exchange for an incentive such as a density bonus. This affordable housing overlay was most successfully adopted in communities undergoing strong market-rate growth pressures.



A reduction in required parking was granted in exchange for a parking management plan that included future parking expansion potential. The Farm, Soquel, California. See p. 74
Alex Seidl

YES !



In My Back Yard

A Celebration of
Affordable Housing in the
East Bay

"YES! In My Back Yard", a booklet documenting affordable housing in the East Bay of the San Francisco Area, by the American Institute of Architects, East Bay Chapter Housing Committee.

The financial and social success of many developments with mixed incomes does prove the compatibility of market-rate and affordable housing.

Affordable housing incentives

In addition to PUD and inclusionary zoning, other provisions and incentives in local planning and zoning codes are also valuable in promoting housing affordability, and in responding to the daily living requirements and spatial priorities of lower income families.

Many affordable housing developments have relied upon one or more of the following zoning provisions in their community planning code to support the combination of better design and more economical development:

- Abundant sites zoned for multi-family housing
- Reduced minimum lot sizes
- Reduced street widths
- Density bonuses
- Greater building coverage allowances, in exchange for interior amenities
- Reduced open space requirements, with criteria for demonstrated usability
- Lower parking requirements
- Acceptance of tandem (one car behind the other) parking arrangements and common open lots
- Acceptance of shared pedestrian/auto courts and cul-de-sacs as secondary play space (bike riding, etc.)

Planning approval process

The planning code and professional planning staff of a community may promote good models of affordable housing, but the neighbors adjacent to any proposed development will have their own perceptions regarding appropriate new housing. Differences between the allowances and provisions of the planning codes, and the preferences of neighbors must be resolved through the planning approval process. This process usually culminates in a public hearing before an appointed planning commission, planning board, or architectural review board.

The planning process itself can have a major impact on a design as various participants attempt to shape the project based on their attitudes regarding higher density or affordable housing. Opponents of affordable housing typically assert that affordable housing is not compatible with their neighborhood because of its density and scale as well as its impact on parking, traffic, and open space use. The success of a project in obtaining approvals as designed and financed depends on its sponsor's ability to show how these issues are addressed, and consequently how the density and design will be compatible with existing patterns or may enhance livability for both the residents and the community.

Many affordable housing sponsors must undertake various studies to prove the compatibility of their development or determine what, if any, mitigation is required. This is a major burden on a project sponsor, and requires a commitment of time, funds, and creativity beyond what is required for other types of projects. Failure to anticipate and respond to the issues raised by the public may seriously affect a proposal, and may lead to a shift in design emphasis away from meeting residents' needs and toward meeting the demands of a few outspoken critics.

Even when public policy, financial agencies, and planning code regulations are fully supportive of affordable housing, the public participation and the approval process is the final determinant of affordable housing design excellence.



CHAPTER FIVE: THE DESIGN PROCESS

The design of affordable family housing is a complex and challenging process that requires the participation and co-operation of the developer, neighbors, potential residents, local officials, and the architect. The architect must help guide this team with great sensitivity and patience to a design solution that resolves physical, social, and cost issues, and produces a building that the entire community can be proud of for generations.

WHO DESIGNS AND DEVELOPS HOUSING IN THE US?

Historically, few Americans had an architect design their home. Even today, fewer than 5 per cent of the population shapes their individual homes with the help of their personal architect; the rest buy or rent their homes or apartments, choosing from among the options provided by others. Real estate developers and builders instruct their architects, if they have one, to create generalized responses for specific markets. Today, about 60 per cent of this new housing is single-family and detached, and mainly built in suburbs. About 40 per cent of new housing is in multi-family units, developed in both cities and suburbs. For the last decade most of this housing has been built by private developers, although an increasingly significant portion has been built by private non-profit development corporations or community development corporations (CDCs), partly with government subsidies. Due to massive funding cutbacks by past administrations, public housing authorities, which used to account for about 10 per cent of new family housing, have, since 1982, built less than one-half of 1 per cent of new family units annually.

Although in a minority, some innovative developers and their architects are trying to reshape community form. In reaction to the wastefulness of the American lifestyle they seek to develop new communities by more environmentally responsible means. These developers are attempting to design more sustainable communities by: limiting the role of the automobile in laying out new communities; increasing density to conserve land, natural resources, materials, and energy consumption (both embodied in the construction and during its operation); combining land uses and community functions to reduce travel time and expand the possibilities for walking; and experimenting with health-conscious and environmentally-sound building materials and methods. These experiments are taking place in middle-to upper-income communities, mainly suburbs, where developers operating in a market of educated customers are enlisting architects to help them develop a new niche in the competitive world of housing development.

In contrast to most private developers, CDCs often develop housing with the participation of potential residents and surrounding neighbors. Although some private developers use focus groups to test their market, they often do not ask the opinions of neighbors. Participation in the design process has been practiced by CDCs out of necessity. Providing families of modest means with decent housing has always required a thoughtful use of land and resources to succeed with tight budgets. Recently, the political controversies around community acceptance of affordable housing have made broad-based input common in the development process.

Historically, this is a relatively new process because it incorporates in a painstaking manner multiple viewpoints of real people for making design decisions instead of the interpretation of abstract market concepts. In many countries, and until recently in the US, government subsidized housing included little or no input from potential

users, neighbors, or property managers. There are examples from around the world of housing developed as ideal housing types by well-intentioned architects, planners, and social reformers that served residents badly, was unsympathetic to the larger neighborhood, and often led to social and physical decay.



A typical single-family suburban street.

Willie Pettus



A new street in a traditional pattern, Randolph Neighborhood, Richmond, Virginia. See p. 210

Tom Bernard



Pruitt Igoe Homes, St. Louis, Missouri.

Public Domain



Chatham Village, affordable rental housing, 1930, Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania. *Tom Jones*



High-rise family housing built in the 1960s, San Francisco, California. *Tom Jones*



St Francis Square, affordable family housing, 1963, San Francisco, California. *Peter Aaron/Esto*

Examples of historic non-profit sponsors of affordable housing

Labor unions, churches, and other benevolent organizations have a history of building thoughtfully designed housing for those whose interests they served. In some large cities such as New York and Pittsburgh, local public housing authorities (PHAs) and charitable organizations began building model affordable housing in the early 1900s. Some of this housing is in use and attractively maintained today. However, until 1937 when the first federal housing programs were enacted, the country's low-income populations were not served directly by government assistance, for the most part. Though initially committed to good design and site planning, PHAs were rapidly pressured by the late 1940s to emphasize quantity over quality. Especially after World War II, when the Depression-era sympathy with the poor abated, many PHAs were beset with deteriorated projects. However, there have been some exceptional PHAs, which committed themselves from the beginning to scattered-site, small project development and designs that were compatible with the neighborhoods.

In the 1960s there was an attempt to create government incentives for the private sector to produce affordable housing. Although some good housing was built under these programs by the end of the 1970s corruption, poor design, and other failures led to a major reduction in reliance on the private sector. Rigid and minimal standards often governed the design of federally-assisted housing; the idea of using market-oriented focus groups to guide design was rarely considered. Only very recently have local PHAs begun to enlist the participation of residents in the renovation of their housing. Even this change in the process of designing public housing fades to insignificance in comparison to the enormous need. After more than 50 years, housing owned and managed by PHAs still comprise only a tiny percentage US housing stock.

More recent models of private and non-profit sponsored affordable housing

Since their emergence in the late 1960s and early 1970s non-profit or community development corporations (CDCs) have become the key providers of housing affordable to those whose income puts them in the lower one-third of US families. Funded by federal programs begun in the Kennedy, Johnson, and Nixon eras, CDCs have been providing people with lower incomes access to the design services of architects in a manner not unlike what has always been available to home buyers and renters with higher incomes. Although construction budgets are often smaller, these developers and their architects give as much or more attention to housing built for families with low incomes as is given to multi-family housing built for higher-income households.

COMMUNITY-BASED DESIGN

In comparison with most for-profit developers, many CDCs make a greater effort to please all those who may be affected by their housing developments. It is common for CDCs to contact neighborhood leaders when they see a need and an opportunity to provide housing for people whose incomes are below 80 per cent of the area's median. CDCs are also formed by local community leaders and residents as the result of a specific issue or opportunity relating to their housing needs. When preparing plans for a new development, the experienced CDC seeks information from neighbors, from their own board members and staff, and from residents of its own developments. Increasingly neighborhoods require this kind of input from both for-profit and non-profit developers as a condition of acceptance of a project before the design process begins. Some CDCs now assemble a short list of architects known for designing high quality affordable housing and invite representatives from a neighborhood to participate with them in the final process of interviewing and selecting their architect.

Neighborhoods are affirming their right to be concerned about any change in the life they have grown accustomed to, regardless of the good intentions of outsiders or newcomers. This concern moves people beyond simply being protective of their private property to being concerned about the quality of life of their whole community. Like the neighborhood watch concept, this reaction demonstrates that all actions affecting private property, whether for private profit or for the larger public good, are a matter for public scrutiny. Hence, people see themselves as having a right to participate in the design of a new housing development in their neighborhood.

People earning below 80 per cent of a region's median income should be able to live where they wish. Those who wish to foster security for the community as a whole should recognize that this security depends on stability in the lives of people of all income levels. Many of the most important providers of service in the community—firemen, police officers, teachers, health-care workers, bank clerks, restaurant workers—often earn less than 80 per cent of the community's median income but cannot afford to live in the community they serve because home prices and rents are beyond their means. Neighborhood watchdogs should think twice about excluding affordable housing, they could be excluding the very people who safeguard their community.

Through thoughtful design and intelligent planning non-profit developers and their architects are assisting the cause of fair housing practices. They both protect the rights of newcomers, regardless of their income, and satisfy the concerns of a neighborhood's existing residents. The architect must then demonstrate a sensitivity to the needs of those to be housed in the new development and of those who already live in the area.

ORGANIZING COMMUNITY PARTICIPATION IN THE DESIGN PROCESS

Experience demonstrates that a design committee (DC) representing the following groups should be established at the beginning of any housing development process:

- The board of directors of the CDC
- Neighborhood residents
- Representatives of users
- Property managers

The board of directors

Since the CDC is responsible for the long-term ownership and operation of a rental property, a design committee assigned to work with an architect should include members of the CDC's board of directors along with representatives of the host neighborhood. Boards of CDCs can be very diverse, composed of professionals, business people, clergy, architects, concerned citizens and activists from low-income communities. Some board members usually come from similar social and economic backgrounds to those of the future residents and will know their concerns.



Northtown Housing Board members at a planning meeting, Rancho Cucamonga, 1994.
Michael Pyatok

Neighborhood residents

The processes of real estate development and housing design can strengthen lower income communities if the CDCs and their consultants orchestrate the process in a way that encourages members of the community to become advocates for affordable housing. Architects who participate in a community design process learn more about the specific cultural and social needs of the families to be housed. On the other hand, participating members from the community will not always share values. Church leaders, business persons, advocates, and neighborhood associations may have different ideas about how the housing and the residents will fit into the community. To identify and address all the different community concerns requires sincerity, patience, and creativity on everyone's part. Under the leadership of a good team the process can lead to both design and political consensus. This process creates a body of supporters who can advocate at planning commissions, city councils and before the loan boards of lending institutions. The expertise gained by people in

low-income communities in developing housing gives them the confidence to fight established institutions for economic justice in other areas as well.

Representatives of users

If a CDC has completed other family housing developments, their residents can participate helpfully in the design of a new one. Because of their income level they may share lifestyles with those being served. They know what it is like to live as a tenant sharing common facilities like open space, laundries, tot-lots, etc. To the surprise of participating neighbors, who very often are owners of single-family, detached homes, the tenants of multi-family, attached housing share many of their concerns and aspire to the same goals, regardless of difference in incomes.



Oakland Community Organizations Board members at a groundbreaking.

Property managers

The design committee should also include a representative of the company who will manage the development. Since renters are perceived to be transient and to have little stake in their neighborhood, neighbors are usually more concerned about rental housing than they are about housing for new homeowners. Property managers are a valuable source of information about how to design durable environments; their input is a great help to both the design of housing and its performance in a neighborhood. Some CDCs send their property managers to annual seminars to gather information about their experiences and to share it with the development teams. Some CDCs include representatives from their property management in the design process, to learn from previous experiences. If this practice was customary, more lessons would be learned and housing design would be improved.

Because most non-profit housing is well studied during the design process and carefully monitored during operation, the property managers and non-profit sponsors of government-assisted affordable housing are often more sensitive to the needs of tenants and neighbors of their housing than are developers and absentee owners of market-rate housing or public housing authorities. Good management in non-profit housing, along with affordable rents, has encouraged families in such housing to be more stable than typical homeowners. It is not uncommon for families living in non-profit rental housing to reside in the same apartment or house until their children have fully grown and left home.

A neighborhood may ask the CDC and the property managers to allow their representatives to participate in creating the selection criteria for prospective tenants. Although the income level of tenants is set in advance, CDCs have some flexibility in deciding who their future tenants will be. Their selection criteria are always as strict as any proposed by neighbors themselves: CDCs will undertake a credit check, a review of previous landlord references, a visit to the prospective tenants' present homes, a check of previous police records, etc.

The number of applicants for rental housing developed by CDCs typically exceeds the number of available units by as much as twenty times. It is not uncommon for a 20-unit development to have over 400 applicants. After eliminating some applicants because their income exceeds the limit, CDCs use their screening criteria to reduce the list to a smaller number who then participate in an open lottery. Because of this process, the CDC will often have less troublesome tenants than for-profit landlords in the same neighborhood.

THE DESIGN PROCESS

Lessons learned from the case studies

Although the case studies that follow represent diverse communities, certain elements of the design process are common to most of them. The typical design process is described below; it starts with the selection of an architect, which should happen as early in the process as possible. The goal of the community design process is to establish a productive two-way communication between the development team and the community; the architect plays a critical role in this process, which has several goals:

- To learn how the community feels about itself.
- To help it become aware of specific issues that affect it.
- To develop design solutions that address community concerns without compromising the needs of the eventual residents or the basic feasibility of the project.
- To create a supportive constituency for the development to help gain land-use and funding approvals for the project.
- To provide a model process and product for future community-based development efforts.

Choosing an architect

Architects differ significantly in their style of working with clients. When interviewing architects the design committee should evaluate several aspects of their past performance:

- Ability to work with people: Their capacity to listen and work well with people whose opinions may differ from theirs.
- Knowledge of the problem: Their sensitivity to the special needs of households for whom they are designing, and their awareness of the social and architectural history of the neighborhood.
- Demonstrated history of similar projects: Their experience in designing attractive developments with similar construction budgets for similar household types.

- **Technical knowledge:** Their ability to manage the project from the initial planning through the construction phase.

Ability to work with people

Developments may take 3 to 5 years depending on the degree of difficulty encountered during its critical phases. Issues include:

- Addressing the concerns of local neighbors
- Obtaining approvals from local planning and building departments
- Supporting the sponsor while it acquires financing and satisfies the requirements of private and public funding sources
- Working with the contractor, subcontractors, and building officials to build the development

Many people are involved in each of these phases. People disagree; nerves become frayed. The architect is a critical player and must be a patient, tolerant listener who can turn many diverse opinions into consensus without sacrificing the quality of the final product.

The architect should be able to explain how s/he involves others in the process of making design decisions. Rather than portray his/her solution as the best and only one worth considering, or provide token participation with a few, preselected options, architects should assist the design committee's hands-on process of shaping all key decisions. This approach often uses three-dimensional, alterable scale models to help the DC explore many alternatives in the search for neighborhood design values that are compatible with the needs of future occupants.

Besides creating a product more sympathetic to neighbors and future users, another important consequence of the hands-on approach is the sense of co-authorship and cohesion that develops in the participating group. The group who participates in this process will be more likely to defend the development in the public forums of planning commissions and city councils who may fear misinformed opponents, and meetings of loan officers of lending institutions, who may fear lending to such developments.

Knowledge of the problem

Whether by designing such developments on their own or while working for others, architects accumulate both the technical and the intuitive knowledge necessary to solve a problem. Until architects complete five to seven such projects under the direction of more experienced architects, or have accumulated at least 10 to 15 years experience, they are not really ready to take one on their own. An architect's travel experience and knowledge of housing design in other countries and cultures, coupled with an awareness of the social and physical history of housing issues in the US, indicate a level of sophistication that will benefit both the eventual users of the development and its neighbors.

Demonstrated history of similar work

Architects must be able to show well-designed housing, which they have completed for similar budgets, by arranging

site visits to similar developments they have designed and by providing a list of previous satisfied CDC and for-profit clients.

Technical knowledge

Although it is impossible to rank the many services supplied by the architect, among the most important are the careful attention to planning and building codes during the design process and the monitoring of the contractor's performance during construction to insure the development is being built according to the plans and specifications and within the original budget. No other member of the development team can provide these services. Given their tight budgets, CDCs cannot afford endless changes during construction because of inadequate drawings or instructions from the architect, or because of ignorance of a detail in local, state, or national codes and regulations. The committee which selects an architect must be certain that the full team of architect and engineers has a proven track record completing similar developments on budget.



Pyatok explaining some principles of good site planning in a participatory workshop.



A traditional small-town streetscape.

Willie Pettus



A typical mixed-use street in Oakland, California.

Michael Pyatok



A lively street in the "Chinatown" district, Oakland, California.

Michael Pyatok

NEIGHBORHOOD CONTEXT ISSUES WHICH A DESIGN COMMITTEE SHOULD CONSIDER

Architects should show their understanding of the role that housing can play in shaping a community and its physical fabric. Depending upon the existing context, architects must either recognize its value or perceive the lack of valuable forms and structure—a lack which a new development could rectify by establishing new patterns for others to emulate. When a neighborhood has a combination of physical conditions and social memories that the local population cherishes, architects must recognize these as worth respecting. Such settings may include a wide variety of characteristics. Some important ones are:

- Traditional residential streetscapes
- Traditional mixed-use streetscapes
- Architectural scale and detail
- Neighborhood vitality
- Historic context

Traditional residential streetscapes

A well-tended public domain with streets of an intimate width lined with front porches, street trees, and well-kept front yards facing sidewalks where people stroll and children play. Garages, if they exist, are tucked away to the rear of the homes. Such neighborhoods were probably designed prior to World War II and the massive increase in automobile usage. The DC should become familiar with the historic development patterns and elements of buildings particular to its neighborhood. They should be certain that new developments have roads, parking and dwelling entries carefully designed to respect these street patterns, even if densities must be significantly higher to reflect the reality of today's housing development costs.

Traditional mixed-use streetscapes

Another successful traditional streetscape has buildings without landscaped setbacks abutting the sidewalk. The buildings have ground floor shops or offices topped by housing with balconies or bay windows that overlook the street below. This is a traditional way of life for people in towns and cities around the world, many of whom work in the businesses below the housing. The vital activity on the street at most hours of the day, the easy access to goods and services, and the sense of community often found on such streets makes mixed-use developments key to rebuilding US neighborhoods. However, in low-income neighborhoods it is often difficult to finance commercial space due to high vacancy rates in the area and lack of disposable income in the surrounding community. In spite of these difficulties, a growing number of CDCs have recognized the importance of building new mixed-use developments on such streets to revitalize the neighborhood with new businesses, services and jobs. The DC must be certain that its proposal respects the design characteristics of such streets.

Architectural scale and detail

To give higher-density housing a friendly appearance in the eyes of neighbors and visitors, buildings should have exterior forms that fit in with or interpret the character of the better buildings in the immediate neighborhood. Attention should be paid to:

- Articulation (expressing individual dwelling units).
- Roof shapes (enhancing the silhouette of a building against the sky).
- Room-sized elements, all of which relate dwellings to the street (porches, bay windows, dormers, room projections, porticos, arcades).
- Architectural detail (brackets, railings, chimneys, entry columns, sunscreens, roof vents).
- User enrichments (opportunities for residents to decorate their exteriors with planting, garden structures, sculptures, windchimes, birdfeeders, etc).

If the architecture of an existing neighborhood has traditional responses to all of these design issues, a new development should be sensitive to but not mimic them. If a neighborhood is lacking in these elements, new affordable housing can re-establish them and become a model or standard to be equaled by future developments in the neighborhood.

Neighborhood vitality

A thriving neighborhood may not always be tidy. Working neighborhoods in which people live and operate family businesses understandably give priority to the success of their businesses. Although the display of wares, the manufacture of goods, or the signage that advertises a business activity may appear untidy, these are signs of hope, industry, and entrepreneurship that may not be compatible with aesthetic standards that impose financial burdens on fledgling businesses. If a neighborhood has these characteristics, a new development should reflect them and encourage new residents to add their own layers of economic diversity and cultural display.

Historic context

Researching a region's architectural and planning history should be the first assignment for any design team. Sometimes new developments are sited in historic districts and are subject to strict design review guidelines that regulate massing, materials and setbacks. In other cases, new developments are in a position to restore a part of a context that has been tattered by poor judgment or the ravages of disinvestment, disrepair, abandonment, or fire. For example, to name just a few such restoration strategies, new housing may need to:

- Reinforce the street frontage between existing buildings
- Permit passage through a development for neighbors needing a shortcut to other places (when security allows).
- Provide open space useable by neighbors and residents.

- Respect the shape of a neighborhood's existing topography
- Provide public parking for the neighborhood

By adopting these measures a new development can complement its physical context. Its social context may be supplemented by bringing in needed services such as childcare, adult education, community facilities and recreational programs which neighbors identify as essential to rebuilding the social infrastructure of the neighborhood.



Tower Apartments, Rohnert Park, California. See p. 90

Michael Pyatok



Langham Court, Boston, Massachusetts. See p. 198

Steve Rosenthal



Safe courtyard at Southside Co-Housing, Sacramento, California. See p. 84 James Kline



Shared auto-pedestrian court, Fulton Mews, San Francisco, California.

Tom Jones



Tuck under parking at Tower Apartments, Rohnert Park, California. See p. 90

Michael Pyatok

Taming the auto

All developments face the same difficult questions about the automobile. Parking placed in clustered lots or in garages at the outer edges of a development permits open spaces within the development to be safer for pedestrians and children. But remote parking areas are hard to supervise. Also, residents and visitors are likely to arrive by car unless good transit is available. They feel as though they are entering the back door when they arrive in a large parking lot at the outer edge of a housing development. On the other hand, if parking is brought into the heart of a development in order to place each resident's vehicle as close to home as possible, the development suffocates from too much pavement. If making room for the automobile and its driveways results in a noticeable separation between pedestrian open spaces and dwellings and consequently between front porches and sidewalks, the social potential of a pedestrian environment is diminished. An alternative to the large, remote parking lot or a car-in-every-house are small parking areas that bring the automobile relatively close to home and allow a comfortable network of pedestrian open spaces undisturbed by driveways and parking lots.

No matter how the automobile and pedestrian open spaces are defined, the number of parking spaces required for a site is the most critical factor for any site plan. As long as land use policies and development patterns force Americans to be addicted to the automobile, and more than two parking spaces are required per dwelling to accommodate residents and guests, the pedestrian environment will be compromised.

One way to economize on space is to combine automobiles and pedestrians in the same courtyards or plazas for a limited number of households with an emphasis on the presence of pedestrians. In order to convey the feeling of a pedestrian space, asphalt paving associated with driveways should be avoided, and pavement associated with pedestrian use such as stamped and colored concrete should be encouraged. Abundant landscaping, an intimate scale in outdoor spaces, front porches, patios and other pedestrian-friendly uses facing the public realm will reinforce pedestrian over automobile use. Speed bumps and driveways that use bollards instead of curbs convey the impression that the automobile is a guest in a place that pedestrians also use.

If a development spends more money on pavement and landscape to create automobile/pedestrian courts that soften the vehicular presence, the local planning authorities should reduce the landscaped open space requirements or permit a slightly higher density of units to compensate for the added expense of the enhanced driveway surfaces. In effect, pedestrian use of the vehicular areas will increase because the cars must move more slowly through such spaces, and hence the need for landscaped open spaces for pedestrians is lessened.

Public and private open spaces

Family housing developments must always provide adequate open space for residents. Although zoning codes mandate minimum requirements for both public and private open space, the design team must consider the actual needs of the residents. Property managers are responsible for maintenance and security of public and, to some degree, private open space; their participation in designing these spaces is critical.

Public open space

A hierarchy of public spaces must be considered for family housing. In many cases central spaces or courtyards that can be used by groups for gatherings and parties, also serve as access to individual homes. There may be room for a barbecue drum, picnic tables, and larger trees. Although courtyards are generally defined by surrounding buildings, planting must be carefully chosen to help soften the edges of a space, to create interest and delight, to provide shade in warm climates, and to keep people back from ground floor windows.

Where there are families with children, the needs of different age groups must be addressed as well as is possible. Young children (4 to 12) will use play areas with a play structure that should be visible from the homes and public rooms such as common laundries. When older children play on the site, they will prefer private places to gather in groups, or more active games such as basketball. If it is possible to provide half-court basketball, care must be taken to separate it adequately from living areas so conflict is minimized. On the other hand, such areas should be well supervised by the housing, secured from the outside and well lit to prevent crime.

The art of locating planting includes ensuring that it will survive the active play of children. All right angle turns in pathways need wide turning curves to accommodate children making short cuts. All vertical planting—trees, shrubs and vines—need to be out of the way of running children, preferably near fences, buildings, and other obstacles that children will avoid.

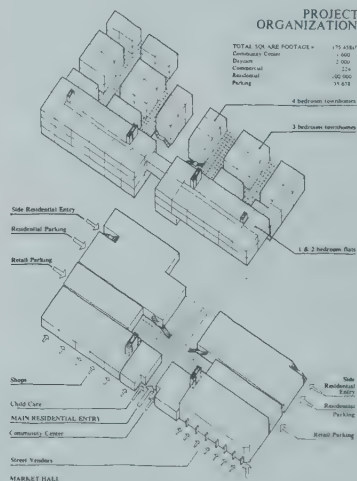
Security

In both inner city and suburban neighborhoods, security is a first priority of residents, owners, and property managers. Stable community life is best served not by prison-like enclaves, but by socially active settings where neighbors are clustered into smaller groups so they can watch over each other's children and keep out unwanted visitors. Contrary to site-planning norms for housing of the last three or four decades, nothing is gained in a social sense, other than trouble, by connecting rear yard areas for shared use beyond about thirty families. If people need to visit friends living in an adjacent cluster, they can walk down the street to their neighbor's front door and ring the doorbell. This adds activity to the street and limits unsupervised roaming in rear courts.

Private open space

No matter how densely a neighborhood is developed, residents deserve private patios, porches, and small front yards to provide welcome relief from efficient interior living quarters. These spaces can serve a number of purposes, including:

- A secure place for small children to play, that is visible from the kitchen or living room
- A place to store bicycles, barbecues, and patio furniture, and to grow flowers and vegetables
- A place to sit outdoors, eat, or enjoy the fresh air
- A place from which to observe and, if desired, engage in life in the neighborhood
- A transitional space between the public realm and the privacy of the home in which residents can greet neighbors, put down groceries before entering the house, and keep strangers at a distance from the edge of the house



Main secure entry leads to multiple secured entries to both upper terraces and flats.
Hismen Hin-nu Terrace, Oakland, California. See p. 100



Front porch at Woodlands, housing for single mothers, Boulder, Colorado. See p. 130

Jerry Butts



Expandable home for first-time buyers, Oakland, California.



Kitchen-dining room looking through to back porch, Battle Road Farm, Lincoln, Massachusetts. See p. 166

Lucy Chen



Rear patio at Tower Apartments, Rohnert Park, California. See p. 90

Michael Pyatok

Planning the home or apartment

Throughout this country's history, the organization of domestic space has responded to the cultural and social factors of the time. This period of US history is no different. Current household types differ from the past in that more than half of all households have no children, and about 24 per cent are single persons living alone. Of those families with children, more than a quarter have only one adult living in the household. Several cultural groups include in-laws or grandparents as part of the household. Because of the recent recession, grown children, who formerly would have left home, are still living with their parents. Each of these household types warrants special design considerations. The current population is better served by housing that provides small studios or separate in-law units, shared living arrangements, multi-generational homes, live-work combinations, and transitional or temporary housing as well as conventional family homes.

Many of us live in smaller quarters compared to previous generations for several reasons, among them the growing scarcity of resources, which has raised the costs of land, wood, metals, and other materials. The cost of borrowed money for construction as a percentage of total costs is much higher than it was just after World War II when suburban expansion exploded. Environmental concerns about wetlands, air and water quality, and non-toxic building materials have added costs to new developments. One way to ease these problems is to consume less of everything, including the amount of housing we inhabit.

Smaller units require a greater attention to floor plans to avoid wasted space and to maximize the residents' ability to place furniture. Private outdoor spaces are important additional rooms to a home; all shared public spaces become active extensions of a household's living space. Placement and size of windows are critical because they enhance views and make small spaces feel larger.

Personal identity

Owners and managers of rental housing worry about what tenants may do to the interiors of their dwellings and therefore discourage most alterations that respond to immediate household needs. Also, remodeling a dwelling unit is an expensive process that has not been facilitated by technical innovations. However, private outdoor space, while also controlled by management, is an opportunity for residents to display their personal identity. Since this multi-purpose buffer space lends itself to inexpensive decoration, it is a logical place for residents to be creative in shaping their living environment.

The opportunity to personalize should occur both in front and in back of a dwelling unit. The front space is usually the place where guests are welcomed and neighbors are greeted and engaged in conversation. The back space offers relaxation and more informal social interchange between neighbors; possessions that residents consider inappropriate for display in the front space may be kept

here. Both these places need some definition in the form of fencing and landscape. However, fences should not separate residents from the public realm. Neither side of a fence is secure if people on both sides cannot greet each other in some way and protect each others' property.

Public art and neighborhood value

Every effort should be made to enlist the contributions of artists to the design of affordable rental housing. Culturally appropriate art produced by an interactive process between artists and residents is a tenant-organizing tool. A strong tenant organization inspired by its own cultural creations instills pride and encourages long-term upkeep and neighborly vigilance against unwanted activities.

Economic development

Even if built in a neighborhood without supportive services, well-designed family rental housing may deteriorate rapidly, and the physical planning strategies used to exclude crime will not be successful. To support lower-income families in a crime-free setting, neighborhoods must also offer jobs, good schools, easily available services, retail shopping, and access to mass transit.

CDCs should not shy away from mixed-use areas. Not only do developments in such areas provide needed housing, they also bring back services and commercial ventures that have fled the neighborhood. Thus they rebuild the urban fabric that has been destroyed by years of disinvestment or limited investment by outside retail chains. Street life prompted by lively business activity supervised by people living on the floors above the businesses is an important deterrent to street crime.

Families who need affordable housing also need affordable shopping. When non-profit developers are successful in meeting this dual challenge, they also serve the larger urban design goal of creating compact, pedestrian communities with a reduced dependency on vehicular transportation. The combination of housing and shopping also supports local businesses who employ local residents.

It is often financially very difficult to include retail space because the expected rents must be lower than what will be needed to support the mortgage and operating expenses. The CDC must find additional sources of subsidy to fund this space, just as it must do so to write down the residential rents. But since for-profit developers often cannot get access to such forms of assistance, only CDCs can be expected to revitalize a retail district with their housing programs.

In the absence of an industrial base to provide decent blue collar jobs, housing design should respect the fact that many families must earn additional income from home-based businesses. Non-profit developers and property managers should permit home and apartment designs which can include home-based businesses operated by their residents. Homeowners and tenants living in market-rate developments are often given this freedom. Other options include allowing

tenants to sub-lease a room to grandparents for social and economic stability or to a sub-tenant to recapture income lost when a working child leaves home.

Ultimately, the best way to make households independent of government assistance is through economic development that provides local employment. This is no easy task for, while most neighborhoods with lower income households readily accept well-designed affordable housing, these same areas often have a hard time attracting successful or new businesses unless retail and commercial rents are also subsidized to absorb some of the risk due to the lack of start-up capital by small businesses.



Children with public art statue, University City Townhomes, Philadelphia, Pennsylvania. See p. 236

Don Matzkin



Townhouses over streetfront retail, Frank Mar Housing, Oakland, California. See p. 112

Willie Pettus



Daycare center at 201 Turk Street, San Francisco, California. See p. 120 *John Sutton*



On grade court and main entry at Hismen Hin-nu Terrace, Oakland, California. See p. 100 *Michael Pyatok*



Simple forms and bold tones at Daybreak Grove, Escondido, California. See p. 130 *Loisos/Ubbelohde*

SOCIAL SERVICES

As noted elsewhere, an individual's or household's inability to afford housing is a combination of lack of earning capacity and a speculative private market that forces up the price of housing when people need it the most. The market responds well to those who have high incomes; apartment rents or home prices meet their income level or willingness to pay. But a limited earning capacity insures a struggle to meet housing expenses. Other services required to help people maintain or increase their ability to work are now being included by CDCs who traditionally supplied only subsidized housing. These services may include: childcare to give parents time to work or to train themselves to improve their earning capacity; child-rearing classes to improve the next generation's chances of avoiding the problems of poverty; educational services to encourage prudent shopping, wise nutrition practices, and better management of limited household finances; and counseling to help people to break dysfunctional behavior patterns and to find jobs.

THE IMAGE OF HOUSING

Reusing existing housing stock and making sure that new housing respects the character of surrounding buildings is very important to today's neighborhoods. Whether in small towns, big cities, suburbs, or rural areas, each neighborhood has accumulated some sense of history in the buildings and landscaping of previous generations. The present generation will also leave its mark; in this way neighborhoods are constantly changing. But the more architecture that previous generations have left behind, the more accustomed people are to these familiar images. Particularly now with diminishing resources and a lagging economy it is harder to restructure our neighborhoods. The instability and insecurity of life caused by global and national economic changes also cause people to want to hold on to the stable images of the past. New housing must both respect these concerns and create images that inspire hope for a better life.

Successful multi-family residential architecture must please the host neighborhood as well as its new residents. In much of the US, adventurous, avant-garde design may not be appropriate for affordable housing. An exception may be parts of the Southern California region where an emphasis on new and unusual design has created a context of its own. Many older cities have residential neighborhoods emerging within districts such as industrial zones that may never have been used for residential purposes. These places offer fertile ground for architectural experimentation where there is less chance of irritating conventional neighbors. Such choices may be driven by either the lifestyle of the inhabitants or the many design possibilities of relating to non-residential forms. When design committees and architects are choosing the architectural character of a new development, whether it is avant-garde, neo-traditional, or a rehabilitation of a historically valuable structure, they should remember that people who live in affordable family housing are, regardless of income, typical of families around this country. They deserve to fit into a neighborhood with a sense of quality and quiet dignity.